

A GRIMOIRE OF THE OLD RELIGIONS · VOL. I

The Old Norse Grimoire

A window to the old world, gods,
oath & craft

DEDICATION

For Huginn and Muninn.
While they return to Óðinn each night, may they also return to us as well.

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Welcome

Working with the Old Ways

Working with the Old Ways

Rest your tired bones and troubled mind. This book shares the old Norse ways, which were about keeping good company with the living, the dead, and the land. It is meant to bring you comfort and a sense of connection with your ancestors. If parts of it do not fit your life or beliefs, leave them behind and keep what helps. I have tried to present these old ways as accurately as the sources allow, and I mark each claim with where it comes from. Use the lines on each page to write, reflect, and build your own practice in whatever way works best for you.

This book covers medicinal plants, but it does not replace a doctor. Never eat, drink, or apply any plant from these pages based on this book alone. If you forage, go with an experienced guide, check each plant against at least three trusted sources, and take only what you need, leaving most of it behind. For medicinal herbs, I buy from Mountain Rose Herbs: https://mountainroseherbs.com/

Where this comes from. Every lore page ends with a short note that says where its ideas come from: a poem, a saga, a stone, a custom, or this book. If a source is late, or scholars disagree, the note says so. Anything described as modern or rebuilt was written for your home and is not an old practice. The main sources are the Poetic Edda, Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, the medieval rune poems, and the sagas listed in Resources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What season is it today, outside your actual window? Name three signs.*

The Poems

What the old sources are

The Poems Behind This Book

This book leans on a handful of old texts, and you will meet their names on almost every page. Here is what they are. The Poetic Edda is a collection of about thirty poems about gods and heroes. Most of them survive in one Icelandic manuscript, the Codex Regius, copied around 1270. Their poets are unknown. The poems were probably composed between about 900 and 1200 and kept by memory first, so their dates are best guesses.

The Prose Edda was written by Snorri Sturluson, an Icelandic chieftain and poet, around 1220. He wrote it as a handbook for young poets, retelling the myths in plain prose so they could follow the old verse. Snorri was a Christian writing two centuries after Iceland converted, so his version is useful, tidy, and late. Where he and the poems disagree, this book says so.

Two more kinds of text appear here. Icelandic sagas are prose stories about families and kings, written down in the 1200s and later. The medieval rune poems are short verses, one for each rune. The next pages give a short guide to the poems you will meet most often. You do not need to read them first. Come back to this guide whenever a title puzzles you.

Where this comes from: The Codex Regius dates to about 1270 and Snorri's Prose Edda to about 1220. The dates of the individual poems are debated.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which poem do you most want to understand? Write its name and why you chose it. Give it two dated lines.*

Poems of wisdom and the world

Völuspá (Voluspa), "the seeress's prophecy." A seeress tells Óðinn the story of the world, from its making to its ending at Ragnarök and its return.

Hávamál (Havamal), "Sayings of the High One." Óðinn's advice on guests, friends, and keeping your wits. It also tells how he won the runes and lists the charms he knows.

Grímnismál (Grimnismal), "Grímnir's sayings." Óðinn, in disguise and held captive, names the halls of the gods and the shape of the worlds.

Vafþrúðnismál (Vafthrudnismal), "Vafþrúðnir's sayings." Óðinn and a wise giant test each other with questions about the world, its making, and its end.

Sigrdrífumál (Sigrdrifumal), "Sigrdrífa's sayings." A valkyrie wakes and teaches the hero Sigurðr runes and counsel.

The rune poems. Three medieval poems, Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon, give each rune a short verse of its own.

Where this comes from: These poems are in the Poetic Edda and the medieval rune poems.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these poems offers advice you could use this week? Name it and one line of the advice. Give it two dated lines.*

Poems of the gods

Lokasenna, "Loki's quarrel." Loki crashes a feast and insults the gods. The next page tells it in full.

Þrymskviða (Thrymskvida), "the lay of Þrymr." A giant steals Þórr's hammer, and Þórr gets it back dressed as a bride.

Skírnismál (Skirnismal), "Skírnir's sayings." Freyr's servant Skírnir goes to win the giant maid Gerðr for him.

Hymiskviða (Hymiskvida), "the lay of Hymir." Þórr visits the giant Hymir for a great kettle and goes fishing for the world serpent.

Alvíssmál (Alvissmal), "Alvíss's sayings." Þórr keeps a dwarf answering riddles until the sun comes up.

Hárbarðsljóð (Harbardsljod), "Hárbarðr's song." Þórr trades insults with a ferryman, usually understood to be Óðinn in disguise.

Völundarkviða (Volundarkvida), "the lay of Völundr." A captive smith takes revenge on a king.

Hyndluljóð (Hyndluljod), "the song of Hyndla." Freyja questions a giantess about family lines.

Where this comes from: These poems are in the Poetic Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which of these tales would you read aloud to someone you love? Name it and who you would read it to. Give it two dated lines.*

The Lokasenna: Loki's quarrel

The Lokasenna is a flyting, a contest of insults, and it is the poem this book cites most when it speaks of Loki. The sea-giant Ægir (Aegir) brews ale for the gods and holds a feast. Þórr is away in the east. Loki has already killed one of Ægir's servants and been chased out, but he walks back in and demands a seat.

One by one he insults the gods, accusing them of cowardice and unfaithfulness. They answer him, and he has a cruel reply for each. At the end Þórr arrives and threatens him with his hammer, and Loki leaves. Two stanzas show the poem's edge. First Loki reminds Óðinn of their bond: "Odin! dost thou remember when we in early days blended our blood together?" Then Þórr, on arriving: "Silence, thou impure being! My mighty hammer, Miollnir, shall stop thy prating. I will thy head from thy neck strike; then will thy life be ended." (Stanzas 9 and 57, translated by Benjamin Thorpe, 1866.)

A short prose ending in the manuscript tells what follows. The gods catch Loki, who had hidden as a salmon, and bind him with the entrails of his son. Skaði hangs a serpent over his face. His wife, Sigyn, holds a bowl to catch the venom. When she turns away to empty it, the venom drips on him, and his struggling shakes the earth.

Where this comes from: The Lokasenna and its prose ending are in the Poetic Edda. The excerpts are Benjamin Thorpe's 1866 translation, now public domain.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Think of a hard thing someone once said to you that held some truth. Write the words and the truth in them. Give it two dated lines.*

Threshold

Who were the Old Norse

Who Were the Old Norse

The people in this book are the Old Norse. They lived around the North Sea and the North Atlantic, mostly from about 750 to 1050 CE, a period called the Viking Age. They were not one kingdom with one border. They lived on farms, islands, and fjords. The sea was their main road, and they named sea routes the way we name highways. Austrvegr, for example, meant the east-way. They spoke North Germanic. You can read their language in runes, letters cut into stone, starting around the second century. Ships, trade, and raids tied Norway, Denmark, and Sweden to Iceland and beyond. Picture a blue-grey stone with lichen growing in its cuts. Its words are short. They tell you who raised it and for whom.

Stones and burials show what people left in the ground. Their inscriptions can be dated to when they were made. Books tell longer stories. The Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda are collections of old poems and myths. Icelandic sagas are prose stories about families. Icelandic scribes copied many of them centuries later. So you have two kinds of source. Stones are one window. You look at what was left in the ground. Books are the other window. You look at what was written on the page. I will tell you which window you are looking through each time.

The sea was their road, and the stone was their record. One man raised a blue-grey slab for his brother and cut the names deep so lichen would not hide them. The Poetic Edda kept what stones could not hold: voices, quarrels, and jokes told by lamplight. Today you live with both kinds of record. Stones keep what people finished. Stories keep what people cared about. When you read, hold both in mind.

Where this comes from: The language, dates, and stones are known from runestones. The Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda were copied down centuries later.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Tonight, spend half an hour at your table. Read one short passage, then write whether it is a stone record or a story record. Write three lines and date them today.

Who Were the Old Norse

This book has clear limits. Know them before you give it your time. No Viking wrote a handbook of belief for us to find. The Roman writer Tacitus described Germanic peoples from outside the frontier. He wrote for Rome, with taxes and wars on his mind. Centuries later, Icelandic Christians copied the Poetic Edda and Icelandic sagas onto vellum, a prepared animal skin. They saved the voices, but they changed the frame. The Arab traveler Ibn Fadlan watched a burial on the Volga and wrote it down as an outsider. The record has gaps. This book says so openly.

This book is not Celtic lore with Norse names, and it is not Anglo-Saxon lore either. Neighboring peoples shared some trade and some words, but their customs differed. Nor is this a modern mix pretending to be old. Where modern people filled gaps, I say so plainly, and I say when a practice was rebuilt from clues. Where old stones or the Poetic Edda speak, I name the source. Where later farm custom may carry an older shape, I say that too. You will find a note called "Where this comes from" at the foot of each lore page.

Tacitus wrote about Germanic peoples from outside the frontier, for Rome. Ibn Fadlan watched a burial on the Volga and wrote for strangers. Icelandic scribes copied old voices by lamplight and changed the frame as they saved the pages. You can still work with these sources carefully. Ask who wrote each one and why. Then you will know how far to trust it.

Where this comes from: How this book works. Its method is modern, but it is built on old sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write one sentence for what you hope this book will give you, and one for what you hope it will leave out. Write both tonight and date them today.*

Who Were the Old Norse

Start with the body you bring to this book. The Hávamál (Havamal), a wisdom poem in the Poetic Edda, values a clear head over a high mood. It tells a traveler to keep his wits about him at the table. It tells him to listen before he speaks, and to eat before he gives advice. Picture a cold morning at the door: boots on, breath showing, shoulders dropped. No one in the Hávamál tries to find wisdom while hungry or half asleep. They begin fed, wearing shoes, and awake.

The practice here is simple. Take three slow breaths and feel your feet on the floor before you start the day's work. This is a modern exercise, not an old rite. It asks you to notice what is loud in your body before you decide anything. The Hávamál prefers a calm traveler. Hunger and rush make judgment worse.

Picture your boots by the door and your breath in the cold air. Let your shoulders drop as your feet find the floor and your weight settles evenly. Do the same each morning, before your phone or inbox takes your attention. Many people find they think more clearly after a slow start. Test this for yourself.

Where this comes from: The counsel is from the Hávamál in the Poetic Edda. The three-breath practice was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Take three slow breaths tonight, with your feet on the floor. Name which part feels loudest: body, attention, or intent. Give it three lines and date them today.*

Which part is loud right now? Name it and say what it wants.

Noticing log, day one. Go to a spot where you can watch and listen. Date it. Write three things you see and three you hear.

Nine Realms

The Gods and Their Kingdoms

Creation: fire meets mist

Before anything had a name, there was a gap. The Old Norse called it Ginnungagap, which probably means something like "the yawning gap." Scholars are not sure what the first part of the word means, so treat this translation as a best guess. The gap was not a who. It was a where: a huge empty space with fire on one side and ice on the other. Múspell (Muspell), the fire world, burned at one edge, and the giant Surtr (Surt) guarded it with a flaming sword. Niflheimr (Niflheim), the mist world, lay on the other side, where poisonous rivers froze into thick layers of frost. Nothing lived in either place. The gap waited, and the power of this book begins in that waiting: when opposites meet, something new can be made.

Then the meeting of fire and ice began to make the world. Sparks flew out of Múspell and crossed the gap. They met the frost of Niflheimr, and the ice melted into drops. Those drops took shape as Ymir, the first of the giants. A cow named Auðumla (Audumla) fed on the salty ice until Búri (Buri) appeared, the grandfather of Óðinn (Odin). Óðinn and his brothers killed Ymir and made the world from his body: earth from his flesh, sea from his blood, sky from his skull, mountains from his bones, and trees from his hair. No one spoke this world into being. Heat met frost in an empty place, and life came out of that meeting.

In Snorri Sturluson's Gylfaginning (the tricking of Gylfi), three gods found two fallen trees on a shore, Ask and Embla, ash and elm. The gods gave them breath, wit, warmth, and color, and the trees stood up as the first people. Today you can take a smaller version of this. When you bake bread or mend a seam, you repeat that first making. Your hands put care into plain material.

Where this comes from: The creation story is from the Völuspá (Voluspa), Vafþrúðnismál (Vafthrudnismal), and Grímnismál (Grimnismal) in the Poetic Edda, and from Snorri's Prose Edda. The household use was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What are you building with your hands this season? Name the project, its stage, and its next step. Give it three dated lines.*

Nine Realms: sky, middle, and wild

The Poetic Edda describes nine realms, or worlds. They are not stacked like floors. They are arranged around one great tree, Yggdrasill (Yggdrasil), which connects them. Ásgarðr (Asgard) is the high home of the Æsir (Aesir) gods, such as Óðinn and Þórr. It lies in the sky and is reached by the rainbow bridge Bifröst (Bifrost). Miðgarðr (Midgard) is the middle realm where people live. Óðinn and his brothers made it from the body of the giant Ymir. A great serpent, Jörmungandr (Jormungandr), coils in the sea around its edge.

Vanaheimr (Vanaheim) is the fertile realm of the Vanir, an older family of gods tied to harvest, weather, and plenty. Njörðr (Njord), Freyr, and Freyja belong to them. Jötunheimr (Jotunheim) is the wild land of the jötnar (giants), who are linked with chaos and untamed nature. The Æsir and the giants are often at odds in the Poetic Edda. The Poetic Edda names these homes. The ring-shaped diagram is a modern way to draw them. Neither the Poetic Edda nor Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda gives a single map.

Use the realms to check your week. The Æsir bring oath and order. The Vanir bring harvest and plenty. The giants bring the wild edges, which you cannot fully control. Each one is needed. Ask which realm your week lives in most, and which one it is missing.

Where this comes from: The realms and Bifröst are named in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. The ring-shaped map was drawn for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Look at your week and name the realm it lives in most: order, harvest, wild edges, or something else. Write three dated lines: one on that realm, and two on where your week is missing one.*

Nine Realms: light, dark, fire, ice, and the dead

Álfheimr (Alfheim) is the bright realm of the ljósálfar (light elves), who are linked with beauty, art, and craft. Svartálfaheimr (Svartalfheim), also called Niðavellir (Nidavellir) in some sources, is the underground home of the dwarfs and dark elves. Its smiths forged the finest treasures for the gods. Their skill shows in what they made, not in how they looked.

Múspell is the realm of fire, heat, and glowing embers, ruled by the fire giant Surtr. Niflheim is the realm of deep ice, cold fog, and frost. At its center lies the spring Hvergelmir, and one of the roots of Yggdrasill reaches down to it. The two realms stand on opposite sides of the gap. Their meeting made the world.

Hel is the dark realm of the dead, ruled by the giantess Hel. She receives those who die of old age, sickness, or causes that are not heroic in battle, according to Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda. This book does not describe the road there. Here the practice is simpler: keep the names of your dead in use, as you do on the Ancestors pages.

Where this comes from: These realms are named in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda. The name Niðavellir and the sorting of elves into light and dark come from later sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one thing in your life that shines, one that is cold or dark, and one that burns. Write a dated line for each. Give it three dated lines.*

Yggdrasill: the ash that holds

Yggdrasill is the great ash tree in the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, and it holds the worlds together. Its branches stretch so far that the Poetic Edda never fully describes them. Its three roots reach three wells: Hvergelmir in Niflheim, Mimir's well, and the well of Urðr (Urd), where the Norns sit. A stag feeds on its shoots above. At its root sit the Nornir (Norns), women who shape fate. The squirrel Ratatoskr (Ratatosk) runs messages up and down the trunk. He scolds both ends as he goes.

Read this as a picture of how things connect, not as a road map. The Poetic Edda and Prose Edda name the tree and its residents. But those copies are late, so the source is solid but not early. No source describes a home ritual for the tree, so this book does not invent one. What you can take home is simpler. Everything depends on something else. Roots need water. News travels the trunk like gossip. You can only tend what you can reach. The top of the tree can have its own weather.

The Nornir sit at the root and shape what comes next. Your life works the same way. What you feed at the roots shows up later in the leaves. Give your roots steady care, such as sleep, regular meals, and honest talk. Results come in time. Notice which roots are dry this week, and water one of them on purpose.

Where this comes from: The tree and its tenants are described in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Draw your life as a tree tonight, with roots, trunk, and crown. Mark three roots that feed you and two branches you tend. Name one voice that scolds you, like Ratatoskr. Date it with today's date.*

Where the dead go: Valhöll (Valhalla), Fólkvangr (Folkvangr), Hel

The dead do not all go to one place, according to the Poetic Edda. Valhöll is Óðinn's hall. It takes half of those slain in battle. It is roofed with shields and raftered with spears. Freyja takes the other half to Fólkvangr, her own field. Hel keeps those who die of sickness or old age in her fenced hall. Her hall is neither burning nor shining. A grim shore is set aside for oath-breakers and murderers. Baldr went down to Hel, and he stayed there after the ransom failed.

Each claim has its own source. That makes the tangle easier to sort out. Valhöll and Fólkvangr appear in the Poetic Edda, so they are named there. Hel's hall appears in Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda and in the Poetic Edda. Both were written down late. Burial mounds outside the stories tell a plainer story. They hold grave goods, ship settings, and feasting gear. These show care for the journey. Stories and mound earth are two kinds of witness. Neither one cancels the other, and you can hold both while you grieve.

Your memory of someone is a form of care. It can last longer than any set of beliefs. You do not need the right belief to honor them. You need to keep their name in use. Speak it, write it, and keep one thing they loved in your home.

Where this comes from: Valhöll, Fólkvangr, and Hel are described in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied down late. The mounds are known from archaeology.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one person who is gone and one thing they cared about. Name the place you picture them resting. Give it three plain lines with today's date.*

Ragnarok: winter without spring

The end of the world, Ragnarok, follows the order in the Völuspá. First comes Fimbulwinter, three winters in a row with no summer between. Family members break their promises to each other, and an age of axes begins. The sun darkens and the stars fall. Naglfar, the ship made of dead men's nails, floats free. Heimdallr (Heimdall) sounds the horn. The gods ride to Vígríðr (Vigrid) plain, a hundred leagues every way. Óðinn falls to the wolf. Þórr (Thor) kills the serpent and falls nine steps after. Loki and Heimdallr kill each other. Fire takes all.

The poem does not stop at the end. Earth rises green from the sea a second time. Baldr and Höðr (Hodr) come back to Óðinn's victory hall. Víðarr (Vidar) and Váli (Vali) live on. The golden game pieces are found again in the grass where the gods once played. The Völuspá tells both the doom and the new green. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda retells the story later, in plain prose. The poem suggests that an ending can be followed by new growth. This book offers no fearful ritual for the end of the world, and it does not ask you to fear it.

When something in your life ends, look for what grows after it. Name the ending. Then find one small sign of new growth. Notice what comes back, and tend it. You can grieve the loss and still look for new growth. Write down what you see, and look again in a week.

Where this comes from: The doom and the greening are from the Völuspá, retold in Snorri's Prose Edda. This book offers no rites for the end of the world.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one ending in your life. Name what grew after it, even something small. Give it three dated lines and read them aloud once.*

Doors: mounds, mist, sea-fog

Many stories say you cross into other worlds at edges, not at centers. In Icelandic story, burial mounds are said to stand open at Yule, the midwinter feast, and the dead walk near the living. In these stories, a mound, the shore, and feast night all mark a place where one world opens into another.

Read this as a story pattern first, not a literal gate. Mounds mark crossing points in Icelandic sagas, which is a repeated story pattern. The Yule opening of the mounds comes mostly from later Icelandic folk belief. Some farms still leave certain hills and landing places alone. That is folk custom, related to the stories but separate from them. Your own street can feel different at dusk. That feeling is real, but it is your own, recorded today. It is not proof about other worlds.

Use the pattern as a way to pay attention. Go out at dusk and notice the edges near you: a gate, a water line, a crossing. Write down what changes at each one. Noticing these spots slows you down and helps you see your street more clearly.

Where this comes from: Mounds as doors appear in Icelandic sagas. The idea that they open at Yule comes from later Icelandic folk belief.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk your block for ten minutes tonight and pick three edge spots. Give each spot one line for what changes there. Read the three aloud and circle the one that feels strongest. Date them with today's date.*

Guest rules: Hávamál manners

In the Hávamál, guests and hosts live by house rules, and the rules are clear. The Hávamál tells a traveler to watch before he sits down. It tells him to eat early, speak little, and listen long. It tells him never to mock a guest or a host. In the songs, oath-breakers lose their good name. The host feeds first.

These rules make sense as household habits first and as scholarship second. The Hávamál does teach guest rules. Folk custom keeps related rules in Yule peace and threshold greetings. They are related, not the same. Today, turn the rules around. You are the host in your own home, and your home tells visitors what to expect.

The Hávamál tells a traveler to watch before he sits. Oath-breakers lost what the songs gave them. The host feeds first. Your own table can follow that rule: no guest should leave hungry. Make that a habit.

Where this comes from: The guest rules are from the Hávamál.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write three rules you would post for tired guests. Keep each one short enough for an index card. Tape the card inside a cupboard and read it each day for a week. Date it with today's date.*

Crooked time: promises across winter

The Poetic Edda and Icelandic sagas rarely run in a straight line from birth to ending, the way modern novels often do. The Völuspá does not move in a straight line. The seeress remembers forward into doom, then past it into green earth rising again. Oaths sworn at Yule were meant to hold people through the summer fights. A vow spoken drunk on a winter night comes back sober at the spring turn. Egill (Egil) in Egils saga is another example, moving from grief to verse.

This crooked pattern is simple, not mystical. The Völuspá loops back and hints at the future. That is a known literary shape. Farm life was counted in winters. That appears in Icelandic sagas and in Grágás (the Grey Goose Laws), where men counted their age in the winters they had kept. Your own year already works this way. School terms and work rotas set the pace, and anniversaries arrive before you feel ready. Many people find that winter feels easier once they stop fighting it.

Use this on purpose. Pick one promise you made this winter and check it against the spring. Ask whether it still stands, and what it asks of you in the coming season. A written promise is easier to keep than a remembered one. Put a reminder on your calendar for the first warm day of spring, the day the promise comes due.

Where this comes from: The looping style is in the Völuspá and Icelandic sagas, and winter-counting is in the sagas.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Pick one promise you made this winter and write it tonight in pencil. Write what you agreed to, what spring must bring, and what autumn must close. Fold the page and keep it where you get dressed. Date it.*

Neither-times: dawn and dusk

Dawn and dusk, the half-light times, appear in many old stories. Your own street can show you why they feel special. In Icelandic sagas, people meet at the shore, where the tide meets the sand. Messages come in the moment between sleeping and waking. In Icelandic sagas, dreams guide both voyages and killings. Folk custom still honors these in-between times. Some families keep a Yule-night watch and draw water at dawn.

Keep the layers separate. Dream warnings appear often in Icelandic sagas. It is a literary motif, a story device that repeats. It is not proof that anyone kept dream books. Later folk dream dictionaries exist, but this book does not use them. This book does not decode dream symbols.

Keep a short watch at dawn or dusk. Stand at one window or step outside for five minutes, and notice the light and the sounds. Noticing the change between day and night slows you down and trains your attention.

Where this comes from: Dream warnings appear as a repeated device in Icelandic sagas. The dawn-and-dusk watch was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose dawn or dusk tomorrow. Stand at one window or step outside for five minutes, and write what you see and hear. Give it one dated line.*

Rǫgn: Gods & Ruling Powers

Aesir & Vanir

Æsir and Vanir: The God Tribes

Rǫgn is an old Norse word for the powers, meaning the gods and the forces that rule the world. The Æsir are the main family of these gods. Óðinn, Þórr, and Frigg are among them. They live in Ásgarðr, the high realm in the sky, and they care about oath, battle, and order. The Vanir are a second family of gods. Njörðr, Freyr, and Freyja are among them. They live in Vanaheimr, and they care about the sea, the harvest, and plenty. Giants and elves live in the other realms, and they are not part of either family.

The two families once went to war, and the next page tells how it ended. The Völuspá, the seeress's prophecy in the Poetic Edda, is the oldest source. Scholars think the story may remember two peoples who later joined together. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, written around 1220, tells it in plain prose. Both were written down centuries after the Viking Age, so the details are uncertain.

Think of the two families as two households that learned to share one valley. Each keeps its own job. The Æsir keep oath and order, and the Vanir keep work and plenty. Each job is needed, and a home that has only one of them is missing something. The giants and elves stay on the edges, and that is also part of the peace.

Where this comes from: The Æsir and Vanir are in the Völuspá (Poetic Edda) and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied late. The idea that they were once two peoples is a scholars' theory, not proven.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which job is missing in your home right now: oath and order, or work and plenty? Write one dated line about it and what you will do this week.*

Völuspá: The Peace Treaty

The Völuspá says the Æsir broke a truce, and the Vanir fought back. Neither side could win for good, so they made peace. Both sides swapped hostages. Njörðr and Freyr went to live among the Æsir. Hænir (Hoenir) and Mimir went to the Vanir. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda tells the same story as a plain treaty.

The peace lasted because each side had people living in the other's home. A hostage was a guest, fed and treated well, and that gave both sides a reason to keep their word. A promise written on paper is easy to break. A person sitting at the other table is harder to forget. The Völuspá and Snorri's Prose Edda are medieval Icelandic story, not as history of a real war.

Njörðr and Freyr spent time in Ásgarðr as part of the treaty, but their home is Vanaheimr. The stories do not describe life after the treaty, so think of it this way: each family has its own home and its own job, and they meet at the table.

Where this comes from: The war and the hostage exchange are told in the Völuspá and Snorri's Prose Edda, both copied late.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one quarrel in your life and the person on the other side. Invite them to one shared meal this month, and write one dated line about it.*

Óðinn: the one-eyed

He rides the eight-legged horse Sleipnir, as shown on picture stones and thin gold medallions called bracteates. Two ravens, Huginn and Muninn, fly out to bring him news: thought and memory. Wolves Geri and Freki follow at his heels. In the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda he is the high one among the Æsir. The Eddas also call him Alföðr (Allfather). He paid a high price for wisdom. He gave one eye to the well of Mimir. He hung nine nights on Yggdrasill, wounded by his own spear, to win the runes. The Hávamál gives his long counsel on wits and measure.

The lesson is in the price, not the power. Óðinn wants to know things, and that hunger never comes free. He paid with an eye and with nine days of hanging. His counsel came only after payment. Later books make him a kindly Allfather for modern worship. That is a modern softening. Jackson Crawford, a modern scholar of Old Norse, has argued that the name Alföðr may mean 'All Order' rather than 'All-Father'. This reading is debated, and this book does not settle it. The Poetic Edda shows him generous and terrible by turns. He breaks oaths too. The hanging and the well stories are told in the Hávamál and the Völuspá. They are not a rite anyone copied.

He meets you as a traveler at the door in a gray cloak and wide hat. He hungers for knowing and never eats free. His counsel came only after payment in eye and hanging. Steady attention counts for more than an altar nobody visits. Give a set hour each week to learning a real craft, a poem, or a history.

Where this comes from: Óðinn's eye, hanging, ravens, wolves, and horse are in the Poetic Edda, Snorri's Prose Edda, and on stones. The 'All Order' reading is Jackson Crawford's, and it is debated.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

What hard thing will you learn for Óðinn? Name the poem or craft or history, the hour, and twice this week. Give it two dated lines.

Óðinn — practice

The old pattern is counsel through study. A chapter of the Hávamál in translation can serve. Learning a row of runes one letter at a time can serve. Reading Egils saga (Egil's Saga) ten pages at a sitting can serve. The student sits at the same hour twice a week and stays long enough for the work to sink in. Learning names and verses comes before any asking. Study comes first, and patience is the manners of this practice.

The offering is attention, not a deal. Copying verses by hand fits here. Memorizing three stanzas fits here. Walking the same line of thought each day fits here. These are reconstructed gestures, built on the old pattern of seeking counsel. The knowledge this god guards is not sold. Nothing is bargained for. Restraint is the core of the practice: you show good manners and you come back. Jackson Crawford puts it this way: "As Odin sought wisdom from the dead, so too do we seek wisdom from those who have passed when we read their words."

Keep each session under half an hour, hands free and mind unhurried. Treat every page of your notes with care. Coming back is the vow you keep. At the end of each session, write one line on what you learned. Knowledge comes to whoever keeps returning to the same chair.

Where this comes from: The study practice was rebuilt for this book from the old pattern. The quotation is Jackson Crawford's.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the study you will keep twice this week and the hour you will keep it. Give it under half an hour each time with phone away. Give it two dated lines on what you learned.*

Frigg: wife and seer

She sits beside the high seat and sees further than she tells. Frigg is the wife of Óðinn among the Æsir. She is the mother of Baldr. She knows what will come and speaks of it to almost no one. She spins and weaves. She keeps the inner doors of the household. In the Lokasenna, a poem in the Poetic Edda, she warns Loki that Baldr would have made him pay for his insults, and Loki answers that he is the reason Baldr never rides home. In the story of Baldr's death, told by Snorri Sturluson in his Prose Edda, she makes everything swear not to harm her son. She works by foresight and preparation. She checks her keys before winter.

Frigg and Freyja may be two names for one goddess, as some scholars think. Here Frigg is the one who holds marriage and household foresight, with the distaff and the keys. Freyja holds field choice and growth. The Poetic Edda names both. This book reads their jobs as one set of duties, and you may read them as two. In your home, she stands for planning ahead. Count the stores, watch the doors, and cool quarrels before they catch fire.

Foresight is a check you make before you buy anything new. Look at what winter will ask of your home: lamp oil, savings, rest. Lay one thing ready this week. When you prepare, you have less to fear. A stocked house sleeps sounder, like a barn stocked before snow.

Where this comes from: Frigg's foresight is in the Poetic Edda, and her oath-taking for Baldr is in Snorri's Prose Edda. Scholars debate whether she and Freyja were once one goddess.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Look ahead one season: what does your household see coming, and what will you lay ready? Name lamp oil or savings or rest and lay one thing ready this week. Give it two dated lines.*

Freyja of Fólkvangr

She takes half the slain to her own field. The other half goes to Óðinn. That shows how high she stands. Freyja's name means "lady," and she is the Vanir lady among the Æsir in the Poetic Edda. She owns the Brísingamen (Brising) necklace. She drives a cart drawn by cats. She wears a feather cloak that lets her fly. In the Þrymskviða (Thrymskvida), a giant named Þrymr steals Thor's hammer and demands Freyja as his bride. She refuses to be traded, and her anger shakes the halls. Thor then dresses as the bride to get the hammer back. She knows the craft of love and of fate. The Óttarr (Ottar) verses call her the prayer hearer of warriors.

Read her as the Poetic Edda shows her, not as later writers pictured her. Some scholars think Freyja and Frigg, the Æsir wife, may once have been the same goddess. That fits how the Poetic Edda treats Odin, who travels among people under many names. A goddess could also have carried more than one name. Fólkvangr, the necklace, and the feather cloak are named in the Poetic Edda and skaldic verse. This book keeps their roles separate on these pages, but you may read them as one figure.

She stands for plenty and for the right to choose. You may refuse a bad deal outright, and welcome a fair one that brings growth. Her anger shook the halls when traders named her as a price. That spirit guides this page. Say no to any deal that treats you as a price, and keep your worth steady through hard weeks.

Where this comes from: Fólkvangr, the necklace, and the feather cloak are in the Poetic Edda. The cat-cart is in Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda. Scholars debate whether Freyja and Frigg were once one goddess.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name a time you refused to be traded. Name what you kept and how you kept it. Give it three dated lines with the refusal plain.*

Freyr of harvest and peace

Freyr brings gifts from the field. His name means “lord,” and he is the Vanir lord of harvest and fair weather. He owns the ship Skíðblaðnir (Skidbladnir), which folds up like cloth. He owns the boar Gullinbursti with golden bristles. In the Skírnismál (Skirnismal) poem he sends his servant Skírnir to win Gerðr (Gerd), a giant maid, with gifts and then threats. Adam of Bremen later describes a fertility god at Uppsala, usually read as Freyr. Kings called him an ancestor. Farmers called on him for rain. Barley and grain are his gifts.

His gifts come with a limit. Plenty can turn into greed. His wooing shows what it costs. To win Gerðr, Freyr gives away his own sword, and Snorri says he goes to Ragnarök without it. The harvest is shown and then shared. The field feeds everyone, not one person alone. The Skírnismál is in the Poetic Edda. The Uppsala account is late and written from a Christian point of view, so read it with that in mind.

Ask yourself what you grew that deserves sharing this season. Pick one loaf, one jar, or one mended thing. Show it to one witness and share it the same day. Freyr honors the yield you pass on, not the big harvest you only describe at parties. Shared bread spreads like seed scattered on good soil.

Where this comes from: The Skírnismál is in the Poetic Edda. The Uppsala account is late and written from a Christian point of view.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What increase deserves sharing this season? Name the loaf or jar or mended thing and the witness. Share it the same day with two dated lines.*

Þórr: driver of the goat cart

Thunder rolls over the hills behind two goats named Tanngnjóstr (Tooth-Gnasher) and Tanngrisnir (Tooth-Gritter). Their cart throws sparks as it goes. Þórr (Thor) is the thunder god of the Æsir. The Poetic Edda and old carvings show him with a red beard and great strength. He carries the hammer Mjölnir (Mjollnir). In the Þrymskviða poem he dresses as a bride to win back his hammer. Hammer amulets show that people in the north wore his hammer for protection.

Thor's job, as the sources show it, is guarding Miðgarðr against the giants and hallowing the edges of life: a wedding, the border of a field, and the launch of a ship. The poem shows his hammer blessing a bride. Later folk custom links him with the same kind of boundary work. The step-by-step practice below is a reconstruction built on that pattern.

In your own life, this is the work of keeping the boundaries other people rely on. Think of his cart stopping at your gate. The gate latch gets fixed, the inbox gets sorted, and the bedtime routine stays steady. Walk one errand in bad weather. Feed the people who work for you before they sit down. Mending a thing keeps faith with the people who depend on it.

Where this comes from: Þórr's hammer, goats, and hallowing are in the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, and hammer amulets survive.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Who does the sheltering in your life? Name the boundary you most depend on and the mending that is yours this week. Give it gate or inbox or bedtime with a date. Give it two dated lines.*

Skaði: winter's bride

Skaði (Skadi), a giantess, strides into Ásgarðr armed to avenge her father Þjazi (Thiazi). She leaves without a fight. The gods make her an offer instead. The gods offer her a marriage and a laugh. Loki ties a cord between a goat and himself to win her smile. The gods throw the eyes of Þjazi into the sky as stars. Skaði chooses a husband by his feet. She ends up with Njörðr, though she had hoped for Baldr. She brings skis and a bow to a short marriage. She loves mountains and he loves the sea. They part, each to their own shore.

Read her as a story about terms kept, not about romance. The story stands in Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda which is late prose. Þórr himself boasts of the killing in the Harbarðsljóð (Harbardsljod), a poem. The joke is crude, and the tale does not hide it. The household lesson is plain: the price is named and paid, and each person lives where they thrive.

Plain terms settle a bargain. Say what is owed. Say what will settle it. Say which place each party keeps afterward. That plainness holds like skis on hard snow. She keeps the mountains, he keeps the sea, and each thrives in their own place. Once the terms are clear, the bargain ends cleanly.

Where this comes from: Skaði's settlement is in Snorri's Prose Edda, and Þórr's boast is in the Harbarðsljóð, both late. The household use was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What bargain of yours needs plain terms, and which shore will each party keep? Name what is owed and what settles it. Give it three dated lines and speak it before the week ends.*

Loki: The Trickster

No devil stands here, whatever later sermons made of him. Snorri's Gylfaginning says Loki was born a giant, the son of Fárbauti and Laufey, and the old texts sometimes name him for his mother, Laufey's son. He lives among the Æsir in Ásgarðr, and in the Lokasenna he reminds Óðinn that the two swore blood-brotherhood. With the giantess Angrboða he fathered Hel, the wolf Fenrir, and the world serpent. His mischief starts small and turns costly. In Snorri's Prose Edda he cuts off the golden hair of Sif, the wife of Þórr, and Þórr threatens to break every bone in him. Loki goes to the dwarfs for new hair, and the gifts he brings back include Þórr's hammer. The harm grows. He arranges the death of Baldr, and in the Lokasenna he insults every god at a feast until Þórr threatens him with his hammer and he leaves. At last the gods bind him in a cave with a serpent's venom dripping on him. At Ragnarök he breaks free. He is clever, cruel, and useful.

He is cleverness without loyalty, and he cannot be flattered into favors. If trouble with him comes near, bring repair and nothing else. Own the mess and repair it fully, facing the person you hurt directly. The binding and the insults are told in the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda. Soft modern readings that make him a misunderstood friend belong elsewhere, not here.

Clear thinking does cold work here, like a knife paring rot from wood. List your tangles. Strike the ones that are only noise. Keep the one that is truly a mess to mend. Clarity is the only answer he respects. One cleanly repaired tangle is worth more than a year of excuses.

Where this comes from: Loki's parentage and the story of Sif are in Snorri's Prose Edda. His blood-brotherhood with Óðinn and his binding are in the Lokasenna.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sort it out: which tangle is your mess to mend, and which is only noise? Name the one mess. Give it one dated line tonight.*

Baldr: The Light

The sources tell little about him, so this book keeps this page short on purpose. Baldr is the shining son of Óðinn and Frigg in the Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda. His dreams show him doomed. His blind brother Höðr shoots him with mistletoe, while Loki guides his hand. All things mourn him. He is held in Hel after the ransom weeping fails. Hermóðr (Hermod) rides down to ask for him back and returns empty-handed. Grief is most of what the sources give him. He stays bright and brief, a fragment rather than a cult.

He gets one page and one use: the beloved who is lost. Claims of a wider dying-god pattern are modern. The telling in the Poetic Edda is late. Anything that lifts him into a timeless Christ-like figure is modern, and this book sets it aside without scorn. Keeping him small is more accurate, and it respects the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda.

Keep one grief on the page all month, without forcing it to teach you anything. Name the missed person in one true sentence. Honest, slow sorrow is better than a grand myth borrowed. One way to help navigate Midgard is knowing those before us have the same loves and losses we experience today. We all experience the loss of something that brings us light. Maybe Baldr represents the loss of love we all must experience and cannot get back.

Where this comes from: Baldr's death is in the Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda, copied late. The idea of a dying god is a modern comparison.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What beloved loss sits with you still? Name who is missed in one true sentence. Give it a day and one dated line.*

Týr (Tyr) of the oath

One hand pays for binding the wolf, and the sources never let you forget the cost. Týr is the oath god of the Æsir. He put his right hand in the mouth of the wolf Fenrir as a pledge while the gods chained the beast. He lost the hand when the chain held. The Sigrdrífumál and the medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon) name his rune for victory. Later centuries dim him, but the missing hand stays in the story.

He pairs with Þórr, and the pair teaches one lesson: strength guards and oath binds. The hand in the mouth is told in Snorri's Prose Edda, and the lost hand is named in the Lokasenna. The household version is drawn from it. The scale is smaller, but the lesson holds. A pledge is spoken before a witness, the cost is stated, and it is kept to the letter.

Choose one pledge this week. Make it short enough to keep without footnotes. Say it to one witness. Keep it exactly. A kept promise is what makes your word trusted tomorrow, the way a steady hand makes a tool safe to use.

Where this comes from: The binding of Fenrir is in Snorri's Prose Edda, and Týr's rune is in the rune poems and the Sigrdrífumál.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Which oath of yours needs a hand behind it? Name it short enough to keep without footnotes. Speak it to one witness and give it one dated line.

Heimdallr: watchman

He keeps the rainbow bridge awake while others feast. Heimdallr is the watchman of the gods in the Poetic Edda. His hearing is so keen he can hear grass grow. He owns the horn Gjallarhorn, which sounds the last day. He was born of nine mothers at the edge of the sea, as the Hyndluljóð (Hyndluljod) tells it. In the Lokasenna he tells Loki he is drunk and should go home. Snorri says the two will kill each other at Ragnarök, watcher against trickster. He is no collector of treasures. He keeps watch.

The watch is the lesson, because the Poetic Edda describes his job more than his stories. The sleepless watch and the blast of Gjallarhorn are in the Poetic Edda. Apply it to home life one step at a time. Keep one bridge faithfully: a door, an inbox, or your temper. Trouble caught early is easier to handle while it is still small. Speak warnings plainly before the cost grows.

Watch one bridge at its set hours through the days. Stand for ten minutes daily at the same hour, at the same post, with your eyes up. Note what moved, and weigh it. Give one early warning during the week, before the problem grows, in plain words with no decoration. Regular watching catches small problems before they grow.

Where this comes from: Heimdallr appears in the Hyndluljóð, Lokasenna, and Völuspá in the Poetic Edda, and in Snorri's Prose Edda.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name your bridge and your watch-hour. Stand ten minutes daily at the same post with phone away. Give it one dated line daily and one early warning this week.*

Days of the week

The Romans invented our seven-day week and named each day for a god or heavenly body: the Sun, Moon, Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus, and Saturn. In the first centuries CE, Germanic peoples, the ancestors of the Norse and English, began using it.

They kept the week but not the Roman gods. For each Roman god they chose the Germanic god who seemed closest.

Sunday · sunnudagr
Sól, the sun goddess, who drives the sun across the sky.

Monday · mánadagr
Máni, the moon god and Sól's brother, who drives the moon across the sky.

Tuesday · týsdagr
Týr, god of oaths and law. He was also a god of battle and victory, so he was matched with Rome's Mars, god of war.

Wednesday · óðinsdagr
Óðinn, the high one. He wandered in disguise, ruled poetry and speech, and received the dead, so he was matched with Rome's Mercury, god of speech.

Thursday · þórsdagr
Þórr, the thunderer. He ruled thunder and carried the hammer Mjölnir, so he was matched with Rome's Jupiter, who wielded the thunderbolt.

Friday · frjádagr
Frigg, Óðinn's wife and goddess of marriage, so she was matched with Rome's Venus, goddess of love. Some scholars think Freyja.

Saturday · laugardagr
The Norse named it for bathing, not a god. *Laug* means "bath," so *laugardagr* is "washing day." English kept Rome's Saturn.

Where this comes from: The Poetic Edda and Snorri's Prose Edda.

Jörmungandr: the world serpent

A serpent lies coiled around Miðgarðr (Midgard), tail in mouth, too big for any shore to hold. Jörmungandr (Jormungandr) is the sea child of Loki in the Poetic Edda. He was cast into the deep, where he grew until he could wrap the world. Þórr meets him twice. Once he goes fishing for him in the Hymiskviða (Hymiskvitha), using an ox head as bait. The trip ends badly: his foot goes through the bottom of the boat, and the line is cut. In the doom foretold in Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, Þórr kills him, then walks nine steps and falls dead from the venom.

He stands as an outer limit, not a patron, because the Poetic Edda never shows him housed or prayed to. Þórr baits him and never tames him; they kill each other at the end. The Hymiskviða fishing and the doom in Snorri's Prose Edda are stories, not rites. No charm to call him appears in the Poetic Edda or the medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon). He is kept at a distance, unwoken.

Respect what you cannot master. Name the big problem, keep your distance, and plan around it instead of poking it. Write down one problem this week that you cannot fix, and one thing you will do to stay safe around it. Like thin winter ice, some things can be crossed only with care.

Where this comes from: The fishing trip is in the Hymiskviða, and the final fight is in Snorri's Prose Edda. This book offers no way to call him.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the problem you cannot master this season, and the edge you will walk carefully. Lay one store ready and mend one boundary and speak one warning. Give it three dated lines.*

Landvættir (Landvaettir): land-spirits

The land is inhabited, and the Grey Goose Laws (Grágás) say to mind its landlords. Landvættir are land spirits in Icelandic story and law. They are honored at landing places and farm boundaries. They are offended by ships that come to shore with carved figureheads facing the land. Egils saga shows a scorn pole raised against them as a curse, which shows how seriously people took them. Landnámabók (Landnamabok) keeps the shore rule of lowering figureheads before landing. Grágás, an old Icelandic law collection, sets price and custom around farm and the local assembly.

The message is plain for any household. Ask for leave, keep the landing clean, and do not foul water or wood. The scorn pole and the law prices are in saga and law. A modern household version is a reconstruction, so test it against your own habits. Well-kept ground stays kinder than fouled ground, season after season.

The land is inhabited, and you are its guest in every season. Clear a path and keep a shore clean, and you keep the welcome. Small care works because goodwill rests on order, not in place of it. The land outlasts every tenant, so it remembers how you treat it. Clean ground rewards steady care over many seasons.

Where this comes from: Land-spirits are in Egils saga, and the custom around them is in Grágás.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Tell me plainly: what ground do you stand on, and which landlord have you never thanked? Clear one path and leave one shore clean. Give it two dated lines.*

Landvættir — practice

Set aside the first and best part of your walk for the land. Bring a small bag so litter is never left behind. Carry out your litter. Keep to the path. Lower your noise near nesting ground. Share the shore rather than claim it. Keep any care small, and do it right away. Leave the place cleaner than you found it.

Count your visits month by month, shore by shore, so the habit stays honest. The pattern is leave-no-trace care, reconstructed from Egils saga and Grágás and fitted to a flat with boots and a bag. What is tended honestly stays welcoming longer than what is only praised.

Finish the visit inside an hour. Note the date and the place in your log before you go home. Walk the shore and pick up litter. End before supper. Repeat it monthly. Clean shores keep their welcome, the way swept doorsteps keep their visitors.

Where this comes from: The leave-no-trace practice was rebuilt for this book from Egils saga and Grágás.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *This month, what shore will you keep, and what will you carry out? Walk it inside the hour with boots and bag. Give it two dated lines for where and what.*

Nornir: The Norns

Three women shape fate at the root of the world tree, and your own luck walks beside you like a second skin. The Nornir are fate women at the well of Yggdrasill. They carve out what comes. Hamingja, your luck, is set out in the Hamingja pages. It can be lent or lost through conduct. Egils saga shows luck turning on insult and on praise alike. Keeping the thread and keeping your luck both require care.

Fate works like a pattern, and luck works like credit. Keeping those two apart keeps both useful. The Nornir are in the Poetic Edda. Hamingja is in Icelandic sagas such as Egils saga. The household lesson is plain: you cannot choose the weave, but you can keep your credit clean through kept oaths and generosity. Luck tends to favor steady people, the way banks favor steady savers.

Hamingja can be lent or lost through conduct. Keeping oaths and giving generously keep your credit clean. In your life, pay back what you owe on time and give something freely each week. Steady conduct is the one thing you can control.

Where this comes from: The Norns are in the Poetic Edda. The idea of luck (hamingja) is in Egils saga.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Where stands your luck today: rising, steady, or spent? Name what moved it and one restoring act. Give it two dated lines.*

Valkyries: choosers

Riders cross battlefields and choose who falls, then carry ale in the hall afterward. The Grímnismál names them in a row, Hrist and Mist and Skeggjöld (Skeggjold), who are the choosers of Óðinn. The Helgi lays show valkyries at work. The Sigrdrífumál (Sigrdrifumal) shows Sigurðr waking a sleeping valkyrie, whom Völsunga saga names Brynhildr, and she teaches him rune counsel. She gives victory runes for the sword. She gives ale runes for the horn. She gives birth runes for hard labor. Her counsel is the part of this story you can use: a wise voice before a hard day.

Counsel before battle works well as a model for hard days. The valkyrie names and the choosing of the fallen appear in the Poetic Edda. Brynhildr teaching runes before Sigurðr rides out is told in the Sigrdrífumál and in Völsunga saga. No rite of calling valkyries comes from any of this, and none is built here. Before a hard day, seek one wise counsel and speak one plain term.

Before a hard day, ask one elder or steady friend for counsel. Say your terms aloud so the other person can hear them. Hard tasks go better with one clear voice beside you, the way a warm fire steadies a hall before a long night.

Where this comes from: The valkyrie lists are in the Poetic Edda, and the counsel is in the Sigrdrífumál. This book offers no rites for calling valkyries.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name your battle this week, and whose counsel will you seek before it? Ask one elder or steady friend and speak your terms aloud. Give it three dated lines for battle, counsel, and terms.*

Blot: simply

The old shape is simple. In Hákonar saga góða, part of Snorri Sturluson's Heimskringla, people gather and a gift is given. Blood is caught and sprinkled with twigs on walls and on people. Toasts are drunk in order: to the gods, to ancestors, and to victory. Then everyone feasts on the gift itself. The full cup is the toast to the gods, and the minni cup is the toast to memory, passed hand to hand. Hákonar saga góða shows the whole round of gift, sprinkling, toast, and feast. Use your own table for the cup.

The old hall shrinks to a table here, and this book does not pretend to rebuild it. The modern blot has three acts. Set out a gift of water, milk, bread, song, or work, never more than you can spare. Speak aloud the names of who receives it. Eat a share or carry it out, with thanks. Nothing is buried. Nothing is poured where it fouls water. No coins are left in springs. The old shape is a pattern in the sagas. The small household version is rebuilt for this book, and this book says so plainly.

One practice fits inside half an hour. Set the gift. Speak the names. Drink the toast. Eat the meal. Carry out every trace before you sleep. Repeat it at the next turn of the month. Passing the cup from hand to hand keeps memory alive.

Where this comes from: The toasts and blood-sprinkling are in Hákonar saga góða. The household blot was rebuilt for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

What gift will you set out this month, and who receives it by name? Set water or milk or bread or song or work and drink the toast. Give it four dated lines in the tracker.

Offering log: what did you give, to whom, and what came back?

- ☐ Water / milk / bread / song / work — date each
- ☐ To whom — name the figure
- ☐ What you asked, in one line
- ☐ What you offered back
- ☐ Leave-no-trace check (carried out?)
- ☐ Week two offering
- ☐ Week three offering
- ☐ Week four offering

Völva & Seiðr

seeress and fate-work

Völva: staff-bearer

The Völuspá is a völva (volva) speaking. She is called to the hall of Óðinn and paid to remember. She tells what was, the giants, the dwarfs, and the world tree, and she tells what comes: winter, breaking, and the last battle. She is seated as a seeress with a staff at hand. The poem also tells of Heiðr (Heidr), a woman who worked fate craft among households. She was burned three times and born again, never fully welcome and never dismissed. Picture her staff leaning by your chair.

Read her as a witness, not a fortune-teller, because the poem gives speech, not method. No step-by-step trance appears in the Völuspá. No drum pattern and no seating plan survive in the Lokasenna, Völsunga saga, or the medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon), and this book will not invent one. Guided trance, costume, and ticketed prophecy are modern. Oracle cards or lot casting sold as old völva craft are modern too.

Meet her text honestly at the table with the book open. Read the Völuspá slowly across three sittings, ten stanzas at a time. Write down what it warns about for the week, in plain words. Ask one elder for a long memory to set beside it. Write the date beside each note, so you can see how your questions change. Listening to real people beats buying a fortune.

Where this comes from: The seeress speaking is in the Völuspá in the Poetic Edda. Trance scripts and modern divination sold as völva-work are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Whose long memory will you ask for this month? Read ten stanzas at a sitting across three sittings. Ask one elder, and write plain dated lines beside the Völuspá.*

Seiðr: fate-work with limits

Two mentions in the Poetic Edda carry most of the weight. Both are unkind. In the Völuspá the seeress says Heiðr practiced seiðr where she could, always toward harm, a fate worker moving from house to house. In Lokasenna, Loki mocks Óðinn outright: he says Óðinn beat the drum like a seeress on Samsey and went about as a witch among men. Seiðr is shown as powerful, risky, and mocked in the same breath. That is all the Poetic Edda will say.

The limit is firm here, because later books fill the gap with staged rituals. No seiðr ritual appears in the Poetic Edda. No step order, no dress code, and no drum pattern appear in the Völsunga saga or the rune poems, only names, scorn, and outlines. Any complete staged seiðr with a circle, staff dance, and guided oracle is modern reconstruction. Any lot draw or card read sold as Viking seiðr is modern too.

The honest part happens at home. Pick one pattern in your house: late bills, a short temper, or kind help that repeats. Tilt it one degree this week by keeping an oath and giving a gift. Fate work here means mending conduct while keeping your eyes open. A small tilt can turn a long road, the way a rudder turns a ship.

Where this comes from: Heiðr is in the Völuspá and the taunt about Samsey is in the Lokasenna, both in the Poetic Edda. Ritual scripts and divination uses are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one pattern in your house you will tilt one degree this week, and how? Give it oath kept and gift given. Give it three dated lines.*

Útiseta (Utiseta): sitting out

A figure sits alone at night on a mound with a cloak pulled close, to win counsel. Icelandic sagas tell of sitters-out, útiseta (utiseta), on mounds and at crossroads, to learn what their households could not teach them. Verses are sought. Dreams are invited. The dead are thought to stay near. The pattern repeats: alone, overnight, at an edge. The mound is cold under your coat.

The limit is firm. The Icelandic sagas give posture, not liturgy. No seating plan, staff drill, or summoned voice survives in the Poetic Edda, the medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon), or the Icelandic sagas. Scripted night sittings sold for tickets are modern. What the sources show is solitary sitting at the edges for counsel. Keep it small and safe: a step or garden, a door unlatched behind you.

Sit once a month for twenty minutes, at dusk or dawn. Carry one question out with you. Do not try to summon anything. Keep your attention open and write down what you noticed. Stillness at the edge teaches the way still water shows the sky.

Where this comes from: Mound-sitting is in Icelandic sagas. No ritual survives, and this book offers none.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What single question will you carry out to the edge, and on which night? Sit twenty minutes at dusk or dawn with phone away. Give it three dated lines for light, sounds, and how you felt, paired with the three day sit log in Liminal Places.*

Hamingja

your luck

Hamingja: Your Luck

Luck walks beside you in Icelandic sagas like a second skin. Hamingja is personal luck and family luck. It is the guardian that follows leaders and families. It grows strong through generosity and oath keeping. It grows weak through stinginess and broken oaths. Men in Icelandic sagas speak of luck as plainly as they speak of ships. Good luck settles on the generous. Bad luck follows the oath breaker.

This method is simple enough for anyone, and this book borrows it. Speak a rule with a witness. State the cost of breaking it. If you slip one day, mend it the next morning and log it as a mend. The record lasts thirty days, long enough to change a habit and short enough to finish. The luck pattern is in Icelandic sagas. The thirty-day household version is modern, said so plainly, and fitted to a diary with trackers ahead.

Keep your pair small enough to do and sharp enough to matter. One daily doing and one daily refusal should fit in a single breath when spoken aloud. Speak them to one witness, even if the witness is only this book held open. Begin your thirty days tomorrow. Each kept day adds to your record, and a full record shows you what you have changed.

Where this comes from: The idea of luck is in the sagas. The 30-day practice was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *In your own words, what doing and what refusal would actually change your luck? Speak them to one witness to begin thirty days tomorrow. Log each day on the two Hamingja trackers that follow.*

Hamingja record, days 1–15: one doing and one refusal each day.

☐ Day 1 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 2 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 3 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 4 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 5 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 6 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 7 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 8 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 9 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 10 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 11 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 12 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 13 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 14 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

☐ Day 15 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

Hamingja record, days 16–30: one doing and one refusal each day.

- ☐ Day 16 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 17 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 18 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 19 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 20 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 21 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 22 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 23 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 24 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 25 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 26 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 27 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 28 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 29 — doing kept? Refusal kept?
- ☐ Day 30 — doing kept? Refusal kept?

Vitki

rune-reader

Vitki: Rune-Reader

A vitki is a person who works with runes. The old word means something close to wise one, one who knows. The clearest picture comes from Óðinn himself in the Hávamál, the Sayings of Óðinn. He hangs nine nights in a wind-tossed tree, hungry and thirsty, until he sees the runes below and seizes them with a shout. Then he carves them into wood and reddens the cuts with color so they stand out. Closer to home, the warrior woman Brynhildr teaches the hero Sigurðr the same craft. She puts victory runes on the sword hilt, ale runes on the drinking horn, and birth runes on the palm. Knowing here is handwork: you cut and color, and you speak it aloud.

The medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon) are the alphabet book behind this craft. They hold short verses from the Middle Ages, one verse for each rune letter. Each letter is tied to a plain thing. Wealth must move. Need pinches. Ice bears no weight. The sun steadies. That teaching is old. What the rune poems never show is anyone laying runes face down to tell fortunes. The Poetic Edda and Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda never describe a school with ranks and certificates. Learn the letters first. Laying runes out to read a question is modern and should be called so.

Learn one rune letter a week from the rune poems, and practice it properly at the table. Cut or draw it on a wood scrap or card. Speak its verse aloud until the sound feels easy. Then set it to one honest household use, such as scoring the loaf before baking, marking a tool handle, or chalking a mark above the door. Hands learn what guessing cannot. A marked tool helps you remember, the way a worn path remembers the feet that walked it.

Where this comes from: The hanging is in the Hávamál, the counsel in the Sigrdrífumál, and the verses in the rune poems, with a parallel in Völsunga saga. Rune-spread divination is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which stave will you carve first this week, and what will you mark with it? Cut or draw it and speak its verse aloud. Use it on a loaf, tool, or door and give it three dated lines for stave, verse, and marking.*

Elves & Dwarfs

neighbors and smiths

Bright elves and dark elves

In the Poetic Edda, elves are shy neighbors. You mostly glimpse them at the edge of lamplight. The Grímnismál names Álfheimr as their home. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda divides them further. He calls one group light-elves, bright as the sun to look at. He calls the other group dark-elves, black as pitch, who live down in the earth. The poems often pair elves with the gods in the phrase "Æsir and elves," and the Lokasenna seats them at Ægir's feast. They are witnesses from the start.

The line between the two groups is loose. The Poetic Edda never draws it cleanly. The light-elves and dark-elves appear in Snorri's Prose Edda, but his split is late and tidy. Some scholars think he may be sorting dwarfs under another name, calling them the smiths of Svartálfaheimr, the dark-elf world. The Poetic Edda names elves often but describes them rarely. They are beautiful and dangerous outsiders, tied to mounds and fields. They are neither angels nor demons. Treat the boundary as blurred, and do not force it.

Think of the elves as unseen neighbors who watch from the edge. You can honor them by stepping softly, keeping paths clear, and leaving one quiet place alone. Practice this in one corner of your week, not in all of it.

Where this comes from: Álfheimr is in Grímnismál, and the light and dark split is in Snorri's Prose Edda, which is late and tidy.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one spot near your home that feels quietly watched over. Name how you will keep it. Give it two dated lines.*

Freyr: lord of Álfheimr

One gift ties the elves to the harvest. The Grímnismál says Álfheimr was given to Freyr as a tooth-gift in ancient days, a gift marking a first tooth, as the poem tells it. The god was young and of the Vanir. The Skírnismál sends Freyr's servant to court Gerðr for him across worlds, and the servant offers her gift after gift. No verse in the Poetic Edda explains what lordship meant in practice.

Lordship here means something like neighborliness, not rule. The Poetic Edda gives Freyr a title but lists no duties. The tooth-gift verse is in Grímnismál, and it is short and plain. The gift binds the elves to him the way two farms share a fence. Any rite that treats Freyr as king of the elves, with set prayers, is modern. This book sets that aside. Read the verse itself before you build any practice on it.

Freyr is linked to fair weather and good harvests on tame ground. Elves are linked to beauty and danger at the wild edge. You can see that border simply: put a pot by your door with tended soil inside, and leave wild seed heads beyond it. Keeping tame and wild in balance is the everyday task. Mending the fence keeps the harvest safe.

Where this comes from: The tooth-gift is in Grímnismál. This book adds no elf-king rites.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which place in your life joins tame to wild? Name it, name how you tend it, and log it with the date in two lines.*

Álfablót (Alfablot): the closed door

In autumn, a traveler in Norway found the farms shut against him. That traveler was Sigvatr Þórðarson (Thordarson), a skald, meaning a court poet, of King Óláfr (Olaf). In his poem Austrfararvísur (Austrfararvisur), he tells how he went from farm to farm seeking a bed and was turned away. Each farm, he says, was holding an álfablót (alfablot), an elf sacrifice, which was holy and closed to strangers. Blood was offered and the doors were barred. No guest was taken in. That closed door is nearly all outsiders saw of the rite.

This is the honest version. Sigvatr's poem is a witness written at about the same time. It dates from the early eleventh century. It describes being shut out, not a set ritual (liturgy). No prayer text, altar plan, or list of offerings survives in the Poetic Edda, Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, or Egils saga. Later farm custom, by contrast, leaves food and drink at mounds and keeps certain hills alone. That is folk custom, meaning ordinary practice passed down, and it is not the same rite. The sources support only a few plain points: autumn, closed doors, and family only.

Picture one farm of the kind Sigvatr describes. It barred its door early and kept the evening shut on purpose. This is one skald's account of farms, not a rule for every farm. You can keep the same spirit at home. Pick one evening, close the door to noise, eat quietly, and speak one thank-you aloud.

Where this comes from: The álfablót is in Sigvatr's Austrfararvísur, a poem from the time. No account of the rite itself survives.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *When will you bar your door early for one quiet meal with thanks? Name the date, the meal, and the people you will thank. Give it three dated lines.*

Elves in the ground

Elves are still present in place names long after the Poetic Edda falls quiet. Farms and fields across Norway and Sweden carry elf-names, such as Álfheimr districts and Alf-farmsteads. Some stones and mounds were left alone by plows, while the plows cut straight through everything else. Icelandic sagas describe mounds honored with toasts poured at the door-stone and paths swept clean. The dead inside were called mound-dwellers (the people who lie in the hills), and they were not always clearly separate from elves.

This is about the land, not about formal teachings. Place names last longer than the books that record them. That elf-names mark the land is shown on stones and in farm-names recorded in Landnámabók. Folk custom still shows farmers leaving certain mounds and hills alone, within recent memory. Iceland's huldufolk, the hidden people, kept the same courtesy the longest. Your street may keep a version of this too, perhaps the corner no one builds on, or the tree no one cuts.

The plow went straight everywhere else but turned aside for one stone. Toasts were poured at the door-stone, and paths were swept for the mound-dwellers. The names stayed on the map. You can do the same on your block: leave one tree, one patch of ground, or one corner alone. The courtesy is simple. Leave it be, and do not take what is not yours.

Where this comes from: Elf place-names and mound-honor are in old records and folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk your block once this week and look for places people leave alone. Mark two spots. Give each one dated line.*

Honoring without summoning

Elves were never worshipped the way the gods were. That limit is part of the practice. No temple to elves has been found by archaeologists. No priest is named for them. The one sign of honor on record is the closed autumn door. Offerings at mounds and hills in Icelandic sagas were small. They were poured or laid down and left alone, with no attempt to call anything up. The Lokasenna seats the elves among the gods at Ægir's feast. They are guests and witnesses, not servants.

The old practice was courtesy without command. People cleaned up edges and lowered noise near nesting ground. They asked leave before taking, and they gave thanks after. No answer or sign was demanded. The mound toasts are a pattern in Icelandic sagas. The quiet-edge practice is rebuilt from that pattern, and this book says so plainly. Nothing was summoned or bound. Nothing was bought. This is good manners, not control.

Nothing was summoned and nothing was bound. Keep one edge this way: choose one patch of ground or one shared space. Ask before you take from it, give thanks after, and leave it quieter than you found it. That is all this practice asks.

Where this comes from: Mound offerings are in Icelandic sagas. This book offers no summoning rites.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which edge will you keep this month, using only good manners? Name place, act, and date in three lines.*

Born from earth and sea

The Völuspá gives dwarfs the longest list of names in the Poetic Edda, but almost no description. After the gods shape the world, the dwarfs come to life in the earth, like maggots that grow in flesh, according to Snorri's Prose Edda. In the Völuspá they are shaped from Ymir's bones and from the blood of the sea-giant Brimir. The gods give them mind and shape. Then comes a long list of names: Northri and Southri, Austri and Vestri, Gandalf and Thorin. Many of the names point to stone, staff, or advice.

Think of the dwarfs first as powers of the earth, and only second as people. The dwarf list stands in the Völuspá. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda retells the making plainly. It is late, but faithful to the story. The Poetic Edda places them in rock and earth, and they avoid daylight and work metal. Later books make them short, comic miners with axes. That picture is modern. The Poetic Edda shows skill, advice, and cost. It shows no comedy.

The dwarfs came to life in the earth from Ymir's bones and Brimir's blood, and the gods gave them mind and shape. Four of their names match the four directions: Northri, Southri, Austri, and Vestri. Stand in your home and face each direction in turn. Name the wall or corner that faces each one. Knowing a place well helps you move through it with care.

Where this comes from: The dwarf origins and name lists are in the Völuspá and Snorri's Prose Edda, which is late.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which three dwarf-names will you learn first? Name them, name their corners, and give three dated lines.*

Treasures from the forge

The gods could not have their finest tools without dwarfs to make them, and every gift had a cost. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda, in its Skáldskaparmál (Skaldskaparmal), tells it plainly. Loki cut the hair of Sif, Þórr's wife, for sport, and then he had to pay for it. He got new hair of gold from the Ívaldi (Ivaldi) sons, plus Skíðblaðnir, a ship that folds up, and Gungnir, a spear that never misses. Then Loki bet his head against the dwarfs Brokkr and Sindri. They made Draupnir, a gold ring that drips more gold, Gullinbursti, a golden boar, and Mjölnir, a hammer with a short handle.

The cost matters more than the shine. Every treasure costs something. Loki's head was on the line, and only his wordplay saved his neck. The hammer's handle is short because Loki, as a fly, stung the smith's brow while he worked. The treasure tale is in the Skáldskaparmál. It is late, but full of detail. No dwarf-worship follows from it, and this book builds none. The lesson is simpler. Good work costs effort. Careless tricks with other people's goods bring trouble.

Sif's gold hair shows the pattern: a careless wrong is repaired by fine work, and the repair is paid for. Use that lesson in your own life. Fine work deserves to be honored, not just owned.

Where this comes from: The Ívaldi and Brokkr treasures are in Skáldskaparmál, a late prose work.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which fine-made thing of yours needs mending? Name it, name its maker, and log the price and date in four lines.*

Völundr (Volund) the smith

A lame smith on an island takes revenge, and the story still chills. The Völundarkviða (Volundarkvida) tells it. Völundr is the greatest of the elven-smiths. King Níðuðr (Nidud) hamstrung him, cutting the tendons in his legs so he could not walk well, and made him forge on the king's island. Völundr killed the king's sons in revenge for what was done to him. He made cups from their skulls. Then he flew away on wings of his own making, and the king was left grieving. The poem holds craft, captivity, revenge, and flight.

Völundr is a warning, not a patron, meaning a protecting figure you honor. The poem does not make him gentle. The tale is in the Poetic Edda, and it reads as stark and early. Honoring Völundr with a hammer and forge is a modern craft practice, honest only when called so. The lesson is plain: skilled people who serve a household should not be held against their will. Skill does not give anyone the right to force another person. Forced work is cruel.

Völundr was forced to work on the king's island and could not walk well. He took revenge, flew away, and left the king grieving. Pay the people who make things for you fairly, and thank them by name. Work freely given and fairly paid is the everyday opposite of Völundr's chains.

Where this comes from: Völundr's story is in the Völundarkviða in the Poetic Edda. Smith-patron rites are modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Whose skilled work do you rely on without thanks? Name that person, what you owe, and one way you will thank them. Give three dated lines.*

Alvíss (Alvis): all-wise till dawn

One dwarf stayed talking until dawn, and that was his undoing. The Alvíssmál tells it plainly. Alvíss the dwarf comes to claim Þórr's daughter. He asks for her as his bride-price, a payment to the bride's family. Þórr does not refuse him outright. He answers the dwarf with riddles about what each world calls earth, sky, and ale. He keeps the dwarf talking until sunrise. In a later retelling, daylight turns dwarfs to stone, and that is how Alvíss ends, like other dwarfs. Þórr wins with talk and delay until dawn.

Þórr's method is plain common sense. The poem gives a method, not magic. The dawn trap for Alvíss is told in the Alvíssmál, a full dialogue with a dwarf. That sunlight turns dwarfs to stone is a later telling. I include it lightly and say so. The lesson still applies. Answer a hard bargain with questions, not force. Sleep on a deal, and it may look different in daylight.

Alvíss talked at the wedding-door through riddles about earth, sky, and ale. Þórr answered with delay until sunrise. You can use the same tactic on a hard bargain: wait for daylight, and make the other side answer your questions in writing.

Where this comes from: The Alvíssmál is a poem in the Poetic Edda. Daylight turning dwarfs to stone is a later telling.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *What pressure wants you to sign now? Name it, write its three questions, and sleep before signing. Give dated lines tonight.*

Stone: iron and honest work

Dwarfs are pictured as makers, not as distant blessers. They make things, finish them, and hand them over with a fair price. Runestones carry the old letters, cut in a set pattern. Rings are weighed true, meaning their weight is honest. Blades hold their edge. Doors shut square. Smithies stood apart from the halls because of the fire. A marked tool outlived its maker by generations. The old north valued kept edges over fine words. Edges were kept, debts were paid, and names were cut plain.

Here is the practice in plain terms. It is rebuilt: this book builds it from the pattern above, and it is simple enough to keep. Keep a toolbox in order and one edge sharp. Commission one repair fairly, and speak one maker's name with thanks. The forge treasures are in Skáldskaparmál. The toolbox habit is a modern household craft built on that pattern. Doing the work comes before talking about it.

A sharp knife comes from steady honing, not from talk about it. This week, spend one hour on a tool or a fix, and let your hands learn the job, one step at a time.

Where this comes from: The forge treasures are in Skáldskaparmál. The toolbox practice was rebuilt for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Which tool, hinge, or hem is yours to fix this week? Name it, name the time you will give it, and log tool, work, and thanks in three dated lines.*

Norse Wheel of the Year

Winter Nights to Midsummer

An honest wheel

The old northern year was measured by work. Hay was stacked in the barn. Cattle came in from the pasture. Meat was slaughtered and salted for winter. Nets were mended and boats were hauled up onto land. In spring, lambs were born and seed went into the ground. The names that survive are Winter Nights, Yule, Dísablót (Disablot), Sigrblót (Sigrblot), and Midsummer. They reach us through Icelandic sagas, Snorri Sturluson's Heimskringla, Christian calendars, and folk memory. The sources are thin in places, and customs varied from district to district.

This book stays close to northern sources. The eight-spoke wheel you may know spaces the solstices and equinoxes evenly, but it was put together in the last century from several cultures. It is a modern tool, not an old northern one. This book uses five northern turnings instead. It marks thin evidence as thin and Midsummer as a folk custom. It watches the moon for pleasure. It does not force a pattern onto the moon.

A year like this is learned by doing. One marked date teaches more than any diagram. One small task you finish is worth more than a shelf of plans. A cleaned shelf, a loaf of bread, and a name you invite to the table each mark the season for you. Start with one date. Write it down in ink, and the rest of the year will have a fixed point to measure by.

Where this comes from: The five turnings are named in Icelandic sagas, Snorri's Heimskringla, and folk custom, but the sources are thin. The eight-spoke wheel is a modern invention.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find which of the five turnings comes next. Mark its date in ink and read its pages once, with a warm drink in hand. Choose one small task to finish before the week ends and write it beside the date. Give it three dated lines.*

How each turning works here

Most turnings in this chapter follow the same five parts. Dísablót has only one page, because the sources say almost nothing about it. First comes the story, as the Poetic Edda and Icelandic sagas tell it. Next comes the old practice, as far as it can be recovered. Then comes a modern practice sized for a flat and one evening. Then comes something for the table. Last come ruled pages for your own writing. Walk one turning from start to finish, and the pattern becomes clear.

Old winters ran on food, fire, and company. In these pages you will meet the Yule peace and toasts to the ancestors, cleaned thresholds, and hill walks. Some of it is old, some is custom that lasted into recent times, and some was written for this book. Each page says which.

Your household already knows how to feast. Birthday bread comes to the table on its own plate. One soup fixes everything. One pudding is always asked for. Your table already has dishes you love. This chapter adds five old names to them. Say an old name over a dish you already cook, and the meal becomes a marker of the season. The table stays warm, and the names stay simple.

Where this comes from: How this chapter works. Its method is modern, built on old sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sit down for twenty minutes and list the dishes that already mean joy at your table. Copy that list onto the reflection pages when you reach them. Give it three dated lines.*

The Rök stone sidebar

A tall grey stone stands in Östergötland, in Sweden. It is covered edge to edge with runes. It is the Rök stone, raised in the 800s. It holds the longest runic text from the Viking Age known to us. Its lines use alliteration, the repeated starting sounds of poetry, and tell of heroes, battles, a wolf, and robbery. The stone was carved with great care. Weather has worn it, but its writing can still be read.

The stone is a memorial and nothing more. Scholars still disagree about many of its lines. Nothing on it lists a festival or a calendar date, so it cannot prove any of the turnings here. Later calendar sticks, carved wooden sticks that counted feasts and moons, are a separate source. Their marks differ from valley to valley. The turnings do not depend on the stone.

The old calendar sticks share one habit worth borrowing. They keep count over time. The moon still waxes and wanes over your street. Looking at the sky twice a month builds steady attention. Short notes kept over time are more useful than arguments about the past. Step outside, look up, and write down what you see.

Where this comes from: The Rök stone dates to the 800s, and calendar sticks come later. No one knows whether the stone had any festival use.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Step outside tonight and find the moon. Note whether it waxes or wanes and write one line about the sky over your street. Keep those notes across the two months of the tracker. Give it four dated lines.

Moon tracker, two months: watch the sky, don't rebuild old rites. Note new and full moon dates.

- ☐ Month one, new moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month one, full moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month one — what changed around you?
- ☐ Month two, new moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month two, full moon — date + sky
- ☐ Month two — what changed around you?
- ☐ Which turning falls inside these two moons?
- ☐ One line: what did the moon teach?

Vetrnætr (Vetrnaetr): kin and burial mounds

Autumn slaughter is done and the herds are housed. Winter Nights is the autumn feast named in Icelandic sagas and calendars. Families gathered to honor kin and land spirits, and to thank the dísir (disir), guardian spirits linked to women and households. Blot offerings, which are gifts to gods and spirits often shared as a meal, were given. Toasts, drinks raised to a name or a wish, were drunk. Some Icelandic sagas show toasts to Njörðr and Freyr for peace and plenty. Burial mounds were visited as the leaves turned. Ale was warmed and names were spoken.

The same date holds remembrance too. The feast has two jobs at once. The living kin are fed first. Then the dead of the burial mounds and the dísir are thanked. The table holds slaughter meats or whatever the market offers. The threshold is swept clean. Frosted greens come indoors. The main job of the day is to bring everyone in, living and dead, under one roof.

Late autumn asks you to notice, not to plan. A fallen leaf, a shorter evening, and a project slowing for winter each deserve one true sentence. Write down what you saw. Over time, those notes become a record of the season.

Where this comes from: The Winter Nights blot is in Icelandic sagas and calendars, but thinly. The details come from later folk custom.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Take one short walk this week and look for signs of autumn ending. Find a fallen leaf, a shorter evening, and one project settling down, and write one sentence about each. Make no plan. Only notice. Give it three dated lines.

Vetrnætr: old practice, modern rite

This autumn practice rests on thin early ground, so treat it as a careful guess. Icelandic sagas describe blot feasts and toasts, and little more. So this practice is openly a reconstruction, meaning a modern guess at the old shape. It needs one clean space, where every water jug and bowl is emptied and refilled, and one clear intent for winter. Small, careful work done on purpose is the whole practice.

A simple door wisp is twisted from straw or reeds. It is a modern craft for this book, not an ancient object, and it should not be passed off as one. Hang it on the door you use most, straight above the lintel (the beam over the door), as a sign of welcome to neighbors and kin. Keep it simple.

One space cleaned all the way beats three half-done ones. Finish it before you stop. Use hot water, a cloth, and a trash bag at your elbow. Write your intent for winter, a plain wish for the season, and set it above the cleaned space. Keep that wish in mind through the dark months.

Where this comes from: The blot feasts are thinly recorded. The space-cleaning was rebuilt for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Choose one cleaning job for tonight and name it plainly: junk drawer, windowsill, or messy shelf. Give it thirty minutes with hot water and a cloth, and finish it completely. Write your winter intent on a slip of paper and set it above the cleaned space. Give it three dated lines.

Vetrnætr: table and kin

The feast uses food stored for winter. Salt pork comes with mashed root vegetables. Morning porridge comes with butter. Dark bread comes with thick slices of cheese. Ale or a fruit cordial is raised in toasts. Old feasts used the food from the slaughter season. Eat in the warmest room you have. Light a few candles against the October dark.

When the meal ends, the toasts begin. A toast is a drink raised to a name or a wish. Keep all the toasts to ten minutes. Raise three toasts aloud in plain words. Toast the kin present, then thank the dísir and landvættir (land spirits). Toast a winter kept well. Finish each cup. The food is folk survival. The spoken toasts keep an old custom alive today.

Three short sentences, kept for a season, teach more about family than a long list of resolutions. Keep each toast plain enough for a child to understand. Speak it standing, with your feet on the floor. Then keep saying it through the winter. Plain thanks spoken aloud link the living and the dead in your family's memory.

Where this comes from: Slaughter-season foods and toasts come from later folk custom, with hints in the sagas.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Rough your three toasts out on the reflection pages first, where crossings out cost nothing. Trim until a child could understand, then speak them standing at the table with feet on the floor. Toast the kin present, then thank the dísir and landvættir. Give it three dated lines.*

Reflection: which kin — living or dead — will you toast, and with what thanks?

Yule: midwinter peace

The dark lasts longest at Yule, and doors were often barred early. Yule is the old northern name for midwinter feasting. It covers oaths sworn over a boar or a ring, which bound people to a promise. It covers toasts to gods and ancestors, and a peace over households, where even enemies could eat without feud. Some Poetic Edda poems and Icelandic sagas tell of vows made at Yule being kept later in battle. Slaughter is done and stores are full. Light was saved for the longest nights.

Folk custom keeps the same shape in plainer clothes. Straw, a candle, and a cleaned house mark the season. The home grows quiet as the old names are spoken. The hearth is swept and the table cleared. You make an honest count of what the year brought, what grew, and what was lost. You do not need a crowd or costumes.

Use the turning week for a small review of your year, like checking a ledger (a list of debts and payments). Sit still for one evening and take out a notebook. Name what finished, what you still owe, and what carries forward. Close one account, such as a debt repaid or a letter sent. Speak the names of the dead over supper, one sentence each. Repeat this check each year to give the dark months a shape.

Where this comes from: Yule feasting and oaths are thinly recorded in the Poetic Edda and Icelandic sagas. The details come from later folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sit still for one evening and lay out your ledger. Note what finished, what you owe, and what carries forward, then close one account before dark. Speak the names of your dead over supper, one sentence each. Give it three dated lines.*

Yule: old practice, modern rite

The old practice centered on feast and vow. The Poetic Edda and the Icelandic sagas record this much. People gathered and a peace was announced. Feuds paused under that peace. Oaths were drunk to gods and kin. The hall was crowded with meat stored for winter. Doors were barred early against the cold. Taking a vow in front of others was the core of the night.

This modern practice shrinks that hall down to your own table. It does not pretend to rebuild the hall. At its center is a quiet supper. One extra plate is set for the dead. Speak each ancestor's name and thank them. A candle stands in the doorway against the dark. Be clear about where each part comes from. The feast and the vow are recorded in the Poetic Edda and the Icelandic sagas. The extra plate is folk custom. The cards you make for the table are modern.

A quiet supper is a small version of the old hall. The extra plate stands for the dead, and their names are said aloud with thanks. The candle burns steady in the doorway, then moves room to room before bed. Old households believed the dead could find their way home. This practice offers the same welcome.

Where this comes from: Feast and vow-drinking are thinly recorded. The quiet supper is folk custom, and the cards were written for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Hold this practice on one evening this week, in under an hour. Cook one simple dish and lay the extra plate, then eat slowly while you speak each honored name aloud with its thanks. Carry the doorway candle room to room before sleep. Give it three dated lines.

Yule: table and door

The table uses stored harvest food, and it stays plain. Pork or root stew is the main dish, and it tastes better when it sits overnight. Bread is there for dipping in the broth. Skyr, a thick Icelandic dairy, comes with honey. Apples and nuts end the meal. The extra plate gets the same portion as everyone else. The next morning, leave a share out for the birds. The offering is shared, not kept.

After the meal comes the walk. One lit candle moves room to room. The route is short and follows the old custom of walking the boundary of a home. Each person and sleeper under the roof is named as the light passes. Keep your voice steady, not grand. Naming people aloud is how a household says it is watching over them. Never leave a flame unattended.

A watched flame carried with spoken names is a way of saying that your household is looked after. Plan the route before the night so the walk takes under ten minutes. Name each sleeper beside the room where they rest. Carrying a light from room to room and saying each name is a small act of care. You can repeat it through winter.

Where this comes from: Stored foods and boundary walking come from later folk custom.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Sketch your home room by room and write each sleeper's name beside the room where they rest. Walk the route once with empty hands and time it, keeping it under ten minutes. Then walk it again with one lit candle on the night. Give it three dated lines.

Reflection: what will you carry through the dark, and what stays buried here?

Reflection: what will you repeat every Yule, even in a tired year?

Dísablót: the ladies' feast

Late winter holds a feast that the Icelandic sagas name but never describe in detail. It is Dísablót, an offering to the dísir. The dísir are female guardian spirits, linked to kin, households, and fate. Some sources link Freyja to them, since she is also called Vanadís, lady of the Vanir. Only the name survives in the sagas. A later February market, Disting, is sometimes linked to this feast. The Idisi named in the Merseburg charms were women called on to help warriors. Candles burn low while the women are named and thanked.

The sources are thin, and this page says so. Icelandic sagas name Dísablót, but no prayer, altar plan, or menu survives. The Disting fair is a late link, a folk echo rather than proof. This book builds one honest practice, clearly modern: a late winter supper. It honors the women whose work shaped your household, living and dead, by name and aloud. Naming them out loud is how you give them a place at the table.

Once a year is enough for this practice. Cook one dish from stored food, and name each woman in one true sentence while you eat. The fuller supper plan is on the Ancestors pages. Naming women who are often forgotten keeps their memory alive in your family. A February supper that speaks each woman's name makes that memory a yearly habit.

Where this comes from: The dísir and the dísablót are named in the Icelandic sagas, but thinly. Disting is a later market. The supper was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Hold your supper on one February evening, in under an hour. Cook one dish from stored food and speak each woman's name with one true sentence. Log the names and sentences beside your ancestor cards. Give it three dated lines.*

Sigrblót: turn to summer

Spring opened with vows for victory and voyages. Sigrblót means victory sacrifice, an offering made for success. The kings' sagas, such as Ynglinga saga (in Snorri's Heimskringla), name it as a spring offering. It was made to ask for fair winds and success in war and at sea. Toasts were drunk before ships set out. Think of the crew at the shore before they leave. Picture tar on rope at the shore, gulls over the crews, and a sail filling in an April wind.

Courage and preparation went together. Crews mended their gear before they sailed. Your household can keep the same shape. Name each member, each animal, and each sleeper, and bless them out loud. The name Sigrblót is recorded only thinly. Decorating with green is folk survival. Your blessing is a modern household custom.

In summer, dress your home in green. Dress a doorway with whatever green the week offers, and let it show that the people inside are named and honored. Names spoken for the people you care for, inside your home, can be kept through the summer. Green over the lintel and names said aloud mark the start of the season.

Where this comes from: Sigrblót is named in the kings' sagas, such as Ynglinga saga, but thinly. The household details were rebuilt for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Walk your thresholds this week and choose one to dress, such as a front door, a garden gate, or a doorway in your life. Use whatever green you already have, from your garden or a shop, and tie it over the lintel with string. Then stand under it and speak the names of everyone inside your circle of care. Give it three dated lines.

Sigrblót: old practice, modern rite

Long ago, the practice centered on launching ships and making vows. Crews gathered and sails were blessed. Oaths were spoken before witnesses. Your modern practice keeps the gathering, the part where a crew is counted before it sails. One candle is carried around the home. It moves sunwise, meaning clockwise, where rooms allow. Name every member, animal, and sleeper in your circle of care (everyone you look after) at each door.

Then comes the greening, the happy part of the day. One doorway is dressed with green. Make a crown from what you already have, such as shop-bought flowers or greens. Keep any flame small and in a safe holder. Stand in a circle, and keep hands and clothes well away from the candle. Never light a bonfire indoors. Never carry flame near curtains. Never leave a flame unwatched.

The old launching served the crew. Your practice serves the household first. A written list read aloud is better than trusting memory. Say each member, animal, and sleeper inside your circle of care, once each. A steady candle and an honest list give the summer a shape you can keep.

Where this comes from: Launching and vowing are thinly recorded. The candle walk is a modern, safe version.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Write your list of names before you light the candle. Include everyone inside your circle of care this summer. Carry the list as you walk round your home, and read each name aloud at its door. Keep the walk clockwise and under an hour. Give it three dated lines.

Sigrblót: table and pledge

The table holds the first fresh foods of the year, which feel like a sharp break from winter. Green salads come with fresh cheese. Oatcakes come with honey. Home-brewed ale is poured where custom allows. Grill something outdoors if you have the space. People in flats can skip the grill and share warm bread. Set the meal near safe light, such as lamps or a few candles well away from curtains. The meal may run later than usual.

A pledge is a promise made out loud. You can make it alone or with dozens of people. Name one voyage you will launch this summer, such as a project, a trip, or a change. Say its course, its crew, and the harbor you are heading for. Drink the cup in front of witnesses, however few. Shared greens and shared meals are folk survival. Speak it plainly and keep your word.

This practice works best when you plan first. Saying a plan aloud to others makes it harder to forget. Prepare for your voyage, then keep your word, even when it is hard. Take one step you have planned, and your summer begins.

Where this comes from: Spring greens and shared eating come from later folk custom.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Write down one voyage you will launch this summer before the meal begins. Name its course, its crew, and where it should end on the reflection page. Then stand and drink to it in front of witnesses, however few. Give it three dated lines.

Midsummer: light that does not leave

Midsummer is a feast that people in the north still remember. Many northern farms kept some part of it. It is a summer gathering around a bonfire and fresh green branches. It comes with flower crowns and hill fires. Tillhagen and other later collectors recorded Midsummer greens and the custom of picking herbs at noon. Folk collectors also recorded fires lit against a night that barely gets dark. Crowns wilted by midnight.

Joy taken with care is the mark of this day. People climb hills, and they enjoy the greenery only where that is allowed, and leave no trace. Food from many hands is shared. Name the grower, the carrier, and the cook. Thank the weather that behaved. A flower means more when you name the people who brought it. Named thanks last longer than the feast.

Share one joy with one witness before the week ends. That is Midsummer kept small. A swim, a song, or a nap in full daylight will do. Choose one joy and tell someone about it. When you name the people who helped you find that joy, the light of the season stays with you longer.

Where this comes from: Midsummer greens and fires come from later folk custom. No old poem is claimed for them.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one joy you will mark at this height of summer, such as a swim, a song, or a nap in full daylight. Show it to one witness, and write how you will share it before the week ends. Give it three dated lines.*

Midsummer: old practice, modern rite

As folk collectors recorded it, the old practice meant a fire and green plants. People walked uphill in crowds. Crowns were twisted at noon. Herbs were picked and hung up to dry. The summer light was praised where everyone could see it. Your modern practice keeps both at a size your week can hold. The hill can be a park slope, or a flight of stairs you count honestly. Your legs will feel the climb.

Taste one summer food on purpose. It may be grown at home, bought, or given by a neighbor with plenty. Then give thanks out loud. Speak one promise of care to someone who can hear it. Keep the promise short and specific. Say it slowly, then say it again so it sticks. Name the food and the person who shared it, so your thanks has a clear face.

In the old custom, greens and thanks belonged together. Climb a hill, speak a promise, and keep both in mind. Pick one clear step to take after the walk, and write it down.

Where this comes from: Hill fires and crowns come from later folk custom. The home version was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Plan your walk tonight so it fits inside an hour. Pick the hill, or the stairs, and write three simple rules: what counts as the climb, how you mark it, and when it ends. Walk it this week and log it honestly. Give it three dated lines.*

Midsummer: table and ledger

The feast opens with new potatoes and butter. Early harvest deserves the place of honor. Berries come with early apples. Fish comes however you like it. Honey sweetens the table. Whatever neighbors have shared from their plenty joins the spread. Each dish can tell its story of where it came from. That is its provenance (its origin). Say who grew it and what weather raised it.

The meal ends with the thanks ledger opened. A ledger is a plain list of what you received, kept here in a notebook. Write down everyone between soil and plate: growers, carriers, and cooks. Then set aside some of this week's extra food to give away. This tasting with its story is a reconstruction based on folk accounts. Read the story aloud. It links the person who eats with the person who grew the food.

Summer feels most whole when it is shared. Extra food set aside for others completes the thanks begun on the hill. A tasting with its story told aloud links the one who eats with the one who fed them. Keep your ledger of thanks, and carry a jar of extra food to a neighbor.

Where this comes from: The summer tasting was rebuilt from folk accounts.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

List three people who fed you this year. Match each one with a thanks you can deliver: a posted note, a jar carried round, or a small gift. Read your ledger aloud before you give. Give it three dated lines.

Reflection: what will you repeat every Midsummer, even in a tired year?

Plants & Trees

Herbs and ash

Safety box — read first

Some plants in this chapter can harm you. Read this page first and take it seriously. Yew is toxic in every part. Juniper oil and berries are not for swallowing. Wormwood and henbane relatives are toxic too. Never swallow anything from these pages just because a book says so. Do not identify wild plants without an expert beside you. Use store-bought teas only. Check every herb against your medicines with a clinician first. If you are or may be pregnant, check with a clinician before using any herb.

Your rule for this chapter is simple. Hanging herbs, keeping notes, and smelling plants are safe. Brewing is limited to store-bought tea, used with care. Meet yew, juniper, and wormwood with your eyes and notebook only. Never leave a flame unattended, whether it is a smoke bundle or a candle. Never drink wild water on walks. Leave no trace outdoors. Carry out everything you carry in.

Keep to eyes and notebook. Keep an expert beside you for any wild plant. Careful watching and a written rule help you learn without harm.

Where this comes from: Toxicity and caution come from classical and modern medical knowledge.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write your own safety line here, dated. Name what you will never swallow and who your expert will be. Give it one firm line.*

Mugwort for the traveler

Mugwort grows along roadsides and on waste ground. It is a bitter, grey-green herb with pale leaf undersides. It is common, and it spreads easily. Northern folk custom linked it with travelers. It was tucked into shoes to ease weariness, and hung over doors at Midsummer. People also placed dried mugwort in dream pillows, in the belief that it brought vivid dreams. You can spot it at the roadside by the bus stop.

The pillow custom does not involve swallowing anything. Put a spoonful of dried, store-bought herb in a small cloth bag, and slip it under your pillow for one week. Three cautions apply. If you are pregnant, keep clear of it. Keep expectations modest: vivid dreams are a hope, not a promise. If you take medicines, check with a clinician first.

Keep your bedtime steady for the week. On the last morning, write one honest line about how you slept. Notice what helped you sleep and what did not, then write it plainly. Keep it short, small, and honest.

Where this comes from: The traveler and dream lore come from later folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Put a spoonful of dried, store-bought herb into a small cloth bag and slip it under your pillow for a week. Keep bedtime steady for the week. On the last morning, write one dated line about how you slept. Keep clear in pregnancy.*

Yarrow in old custom: look, don't use

Yarrow is easy to recognize once you learn its signs. Its leaves are feathery, like green lace. Its flat white flower heads stand along hedges all summer. Old books call it soldier's woundwort. Folk custom in many countries linked it with stopping bleeding (staunching). Some people used it for small cuts in the past. Today this book asks you only to look at it. Any old footpath in July passes a dozen clumps.

Treat this plant with care, and do not use it. Yarrow can cause skin irritation in some people. If your skin reacts easily, wear gloves when you touch it. This book does not ask you to apply it, eat it, or brew it. Never use it in place of prescribed medicine. Never use it for deep or doubtful wounds. Safety comes first.

Counting ten clumps teaches you the plant better than any book can. Sketch one leaf, and you will remember its shape more clearly than from a pressed specimen. Note the damp and trodden ground where it grows. A plant you have counted and drawn stays familiar when you need to recognize it.

Where this comes from: Yarrow's use for wounds appears in classical and folk sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *On your next walk, count every yarrow clump you pass and note where the ground is damp or trodden. Sketch one leaf in five plain lines. Count ten clumps. Do not gather anything. Give it three dated lines.*

Juniper: clean smoke — no ingest

Juniper stays blue-green through snow. Its berries are dusted with a pale bloom. Its smoke is sharp and clean. Northern farms burned juniper sprigs to cleanse the house and the byre, the cattle shed, before feasts. Some laid boughs on the floor to freshen the air. Folk collectors recorded cleansing with juniper smoke at Yule and at the spring turn, a custom of cleansing a place of harm. The smoke often hung low in the doorway at dusk. Burning it still fills a room with that smell.

Smoke is the only use here. Berries stay out of the kitchen. Juniper berries and juniper oil are harsh on the kidneys when taken in quantity. Never swallow them. This book never asks you to brew or swallow them. Its only use is cleansing smoke. Burn a bought bundle in a fire-safe dish, with a window cracked. Never leave it unattended. Keep the burning dish away from curtains and bedding.

Keep the smoke near the doorway, as old households did. Burn a small bought bundle while you watch it, or skip the smoke. Keep a window cracked while you burn it. Open a window, shake out the bedding, and air the room. Clean smoke and fresh air make the house ready for a feast.

Where this comes from: Juniper cleansing comes from northern folk custom. The rule against swallowing it is modern medical advice.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Air one room this week the old way. Open the window, shake the bedding, and sweep under the bed, then note the date aired and the weather. If you burn a bought bundle, burn it small and watched in a fire-safe dish. Give it three dated lines.*

Birch leaves: first green

Birch leafs out first, in a fresh, bright green. Its white bark peels in thin scrolls. Northern custom ties birch twigs into bundles called switches or whisks, used in the sauna. Folk tea used young leaves, and today you would buy them dried in packets. That tea is mild and fresh, like spring. Look up at the full leaves above you. Stand close and smell the damp, fresh air.

Being named in folk custom is an honor, not a prescription. Your own use stays small, bought, and written down. Bought dried leaf only, and one cup at a time, logged with date and amount. Never use it in place of anything a doctor prescribed. Check with a clinician first if you take regular medicines or could be pregnant.

A mild spring cup, taken with care and a written note, honors the first green. Watching two birches each month makes a calendar of the seasons where you live. Each visit teaches you what to expect next time. Watch the first leaves each year, and you will learn when to look again.

Where this comes from: Birch spring custom and leaf tea come from folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose two birches near your walk. Visit them monthly, from first leaf to last gold. Write one line each visit with date, stage, and weather. Write the clinician caution twice beside your log. Give it monthly dated lines.*

Pine: tar and light

Pine was one of the most useful trees in the north. Its wood gave ship timbers and masts, and its resin was boiled into tar for sealing boats and rope. Resin-rich pine wood, called torchwood, was split for light. Knotty roots were split for kindling, and that kindling carried light through the Yule dark. In a pine stand at noon, the scent is thick. Light falls in shafts between trunks.

Pine is handled today as a source of light and warmth, mostly in small amounts you buy. Thank the wood as you use it, for its resin and its kindling. Buy firewood or kindling honestly instead of cutting trees yourself. Write the date you bought or used it in the same notebook. Dry kindling you buy is more useful than big plans about forests. Use only what you have bought or been given.

A tree you visit each year becomes a fixed point, something steady to measure the seasons by. Dry kindling you buy can light your midwinter nights. Visit one pine, note its date and how it stands, and it becomes a steady marker for your year.

Where this comes from: Pine tar and torchwood appear in sagas and folk life.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find your nearest pine this week. Record where it grows and how it stands with date, then return at midwinter dark and add one line about light. Give it three dated lines.*

Nettle: respect the sting

You probably know nettle by its sting. It stings bare hands, so always wear gloves near it. In the past, young spring tops went into soups, dried leaves made a tea, and stems were twisted into cord. Few plants teach a simpler lesson. The plant that stings careless hands is useful to careful ones. A patch by the fence is often the first green of spring. The sting teaches you to wear gloves.

Gloves come before any use of this plant. Do not pick nettle for soup unless an expert has confirmed the plant with you in person. A book's description is never enough to identify a plant. Without that, use store-bought dried leaf for tea, and log each cup with date and amount. If you are stung, wash the area with cold water and watch it closely.

The order matters: gloves first, then any use. One cup of bought tea, tasted slowly, teaches the whole lesson. Log the taste in your notes, and stop there. Gloved hands that respect the sting can enjoy the spring tea safely.

Where this comes from: Nettle as food and fiber appears in old sources and folk life.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Brew one cup of bought nettle leaf tea this spring and drink it slowly, noticing its earthy green taste. Log it with date and amount, and write which gloves you will wear if you ever handle nettle with an expert. Give it three dated lines.

Elderflower cordial season

Elderflower arrives all at once in early summer. Hedges look foamed with white blossom. Folk custom turned the flowers into a sweet cordial, a drink made with sugar and water. The elder tree is treated as a lady to be asked before cutting. Thanks are spoken before any bloom is taken. Enjoy the scent from where you stand, and leave the blossom on the tree. Notice how the white heads look against the green hedge.

The berries come later, and the rules here are strict. Do not eat raw berries or green parts of the plant. This book does not ask you to pick elder. Use store-bought elderflower cordial or syrup instead, and follow the label. If you take medicines or are pregnant, check with a clinician first. Label every jar with the date you opened it.

A tree greeted properly is said to give twice: June flowers and autumn berries. Watching the tree through both seasons is the practice. Labeled jars of bought cordial carry the season into winter. Speaking thanks before taking anything is a habit that keeps the whole season sweet.

Where this comes from: Elder cordial and asking before cutting come from folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose two elders near your walk. Visit them monthly, from first bloom to last berry. Write one line each visit with date, stage, and weather. Do not pick anything. Give it monthly dated lines.*

Plantain of the wayside

Plantain grows flat where feet go. Its ribbed leaves press close to the path. Its flower spikes rise like thin green candles. Folk custom gave it names like waybread and wound leaf. Old custom sometimes used the leaf on sores and blisters. This book does not. In hard years, its seeds were saved and added to porridge. It stays low, gets stepped on, and still grows back.

This book does not ask you to use plantain on your body or in food. The old uses are history, not instructions. If you ever want to use a plantain product, buy it, follow the label, and check with a clinician first. Never use it in place of prescribed care, and never use it on deep or dirty wounds. Read this rule again if you are unsure.

A plant you describe in your own sentences stays in memory longer than one you only read about. Spend ten minutes with the ribbed leaves and spikes. Study the leaves where they grow, and you will recognize this plant wherever you walk.

Where this comes from: Plantain's wayside uses come from folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Find a plantain on a path and study its ribbed leaves and spikes for ten minutes. Sketch it in five lines, and write the clinician caution twice beside your log. Do not pick or use any part of it. Give it three dated lines.*

Meadowsweet: mead-wort

Meadowsweet grows in damp meadows and sweetens the air in high summer. Its creamy flower heads nod over ditches. You often smell almond before you see it. Folk custom kept it to flavor mead, a honey drink, and summer cordials. The Swedish name mjodort means mead wort, which fits its use in mead. On a hot day, a full stand hums with insects. Its scent and its use were linked.

Old books name this plant, but a name is not permission to use it. Your use stays small, bought, and written down. Bought dried flowers only, and one cup at a time, logged with date and amount. Never use it in place of doctor's orders. It contains salicylates, a family of compounds that aspirin is related to. Anyone on medicines should check with a clinician first. Tell your doctor if you use it.

A single cup, tasted slowly and logged honestly, is the monthly practice. Notice the almond, the hay, or the river in its scent before the cup cools. Give the plant fifteen minutes of full attention.

Where this comes from: The name mead-wort and its tea use come from old sources and folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Check with a clinician first if you take medicines or are pregnant. Then brew one cup of bought meadowsweet tea on some unhurried afternoon, and give it fifteen minutes of full attention. Note what the scent reminds you of and write three lines before the cup cools, logged with date and amount. Give it three dated lines.*

First meetings: where does your chosen ally grow, and when will you visit it across the seasons?

Ash: the world tree

In Grímnismál (Grimnir's sayings), the ash tree Yggdrasill holds up the nine worlds. You can see why when you stand beneath a large one. Its bark is grey and ridged. Its buds are black. Its winged seeds hang in bunches. Its timber is springy and strong, so it was used for spears and tool handles. In the Poetic Edda, Yggdrasill is an ash, and its roots reach to wells where the Nornir (the Norns, who shape fate) sit. Put your palm on the bark. It feels cool and straight.

This tree grows straight. Year after year it adds steady wood, the kind once used for spears and shafts. Think of it as a picture of patient, steady work. Its straight trunk shows steady growth over many years.

Visit one ash in each of the four seasons, and it becomes a familiar friend. Watch the buds open and the birds change above the bark. Tell it one short piece of news, and notice what has changed when you return. Walking with one tree through the year gives you a steady place to measure your own growth.

Where this comes from: The ash as world-tree is in the Poetic Edda, and ash timber was widely used.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose one long project in your life, such as a skill, a repair, or a savings goal. Visit an ash tree this week for twenty minutes, and write where it stands as your first entry. Then log it across all four seasons. Give it four dated lines.*

Birch: bright beginner

Birch leads the spring, with white bark and bright green leaves. It is among the first trees to leaf and among the first to turn gold. Northern farms used its bark for containers and roofing. Poets often mention birch beside pools. Coppice workers (people who cut young shoots for reuse) cut birch rods for baskets. One small tree serves many uses. Peel only bark that has already fallen. Never cut a ring around a living trunk, which can kill the tree.

Learning comes lightly, in small steps, and it takes time. A single sentence heard in passing can change how you see a problem. It rarely arrives all at once. One reading, one walk, and one conversation a week keep it growing.

Small gains add up over time. A shared meal, something you make, or a good talk can help. Name the person who helped, and you will remember the lesson longer. Watch for these gains for one month.

Where this comes from: Birch use appears in sagas and folk life.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Carry one question for a full month. Each week, do one reading, take one walk, and have one conversation about it. At the end, name one new insight, where it came from, and who helped you see it. Give it four dated lines.

Rowan at the threshold

Rowan trees grow near doorways across northern countries. People planted it beside houses and holy wells. Old custom trusted it on doorways, gateposts, and cradles, believing it guarded against harm. It is a small tree with a light crown. Its berries stand scarlet against grey stone. People valued it as a guard more than as timber. Look for rowans near doors as you walk. Stop and look at the berries when you pass one.

You can care for a rowan in plain ways. Your part is to notice it often. Take only fallen wood, and never cut a branch without permission. You can write a blessing, put it in a small bag with a fallen twig, and hang it by the door.

A threshold you name and tend feels different from one you only lock. Put a hand on the frame, take one breath, and say one kind sentence as you cross, each day for a week. Watching over a doorway keeps your home in mind.

Where this comes from: Rowan at the threshold is a folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one threshold in your life that needs more care tonight, such as a front door, a bedroom door, your inbox, or your temper. For one week, greet it with a hand on the frame and one kind sentence. Then write what changed. Give it three dated lines.*

Yew of the dead — no ingest

Yew can outlive the trees around it. It stands dark green against grey stone through every month. Its wood was prized for bows in many lands. Modern plant science confirms that every part of yew is poisonous. Take no teas, no berries, and no experiments. Keep the old lore on the page, and keep it out of your cup, your pot, and your hands. Look, remember, and touch nothing.

Remembrance, not use, is the meaning of this tree. Yews often grow in churchyards and gardens, where they give shade. Sit beside one and think of whoever comes to mind. Take nothing away except notes. Take no clippings, no berries, and no bark. The ash page is about steady patience. The yew is about remembering the dead, Its danger is why you only sit beside it.

Being present here asks for no ritual and no request. Keep your phone in your pocket and a notebook open. Let names come to you without chasing them. Quiet minutes under dark green branches are a way of honoring the dead.

Where this comes from: Yew's link to the dead is an old association, and its poison is a plain fact. The rule against swallowing it is modern medical advice.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Sit ten quiet minutes beside a yew this week, and do not touch it. Keep your phone away and a notebook open. Let names come to mind, then write down who came in one honest line. Give it one dated line.*

Oak: the slow king

Oak measures time in centuries. You feel it when you stand under one. Its timber built ships and door posts in the north. Oaks can stand for hundreds of years, even with hollow trunks. In old stories, the oak is a central, steady tree. Put your palm on the bark. It feels ridged, cold, and steady. A lone oak in a field often stands for generations. Stand close and feel its size.

The oak takes its time. Season after season it adds slow, strong wood. An old oak can keep standing with a hollow trunk. This tree teaches you to think in seasons, not days.

Watching an oak through the seasons keeps you steady. Guess its girth (width around the trunk), note the birds, and tell it a short piece of news, year after year. One oak followed through all four seasons gives your year a steady point to return to.

Where this comes from: Oak timber and long life appear in sagas and folk life.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose one oak near you and walk to it this week, taking about twenty minutes. Note where it stands and how it looks today, including its lean, its branches, and the light. Then log it across all four seasons. Give it four dated lines.*

Plant ally log: name your ally from these pages, then log its leaf, flower, seed, and date at each turning.

Seasonal gathering calendar: what will you gather, where, and in which month? Ask-first rule noted.

Liminal Places

Wells that remember

Wells and the gifts left in them

Bog water and spring water have kept things for a very long time. Long ago, people laid swords, cauldrons, and brooches in lakes, bogs, and springs. Diggers still find them where rivers slow and springs rise. Scholars call these gifts votive deposits. That means objects given on purpose to a place. The custom did not fully die out. At holy wells in the northern and western lands, people still walk a circle (called a round) around the water and tie cloth to a tree or post above it. Some old gifts went in whole and some did not. What mattered most was the giving itself.

A well is a place with its own history. It is not a machine that grants wishes. Old deposits are well documented: they were found, lifted from the ground, and recorded. Rounds and cloth trees are living folk customs, kept by families who look after each site. Tossing coins into a living spring is a newer habit of visitors, and coins can pollute the water. Never drink wild water, because you cannot know what is in it.

When you visit, walk the round as it is kept at each place. Where no round is marked, walk once around sunwise, meaning clockwise in the northern half of the world. Tie only cloth that will rot away, such as natural cotton or wool. Ask leave before you lift any water, and sit a while to listen before you leave. Where the well is built over, stand at the nearest marked spot instead. The visit takes under an hour. Take nothing away from the site, and leave only what you chose to give. Keep any promise you made to the place.

Where this comes from: Old gifts in lakes and springs are found by archaeology. Rounds and cloth trees are living folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name your nearest spring or well. Give the day you will go, the round you will walk, and what you will leave there. Write it in three dated lines.*

Sea roads

In Icelandic sagas such as Egils saga, the sea is a road between farms that could never meet by land. Sailors had to follow its rules. Some Icelandic sagas show voyages that begin with vows and end with thanks. Some mention gifts to the sea and wind. The crew keeps to its place, and the oars are stowed in order. A shore belongs to neither farm. Storytellers use open water as the setting for hard bargains and farewells. Promises made on the crossing are held to account, meaning people check whether they were kept.

Mid-voyage has its own rule. No shore owns the middle of the water, so every promise made there must be said out loud and kept. Icelandic sagas show crews naming what they leave and what they carry. They speak their terms aloud while still on the water. To reach the far bank, say your terms plainly and keep them.

Many people now live with an unfinished move, a half-paid house, or a task that was never finished. The old idea of a crossing still helps. Every crossing has a bank behind you and a bank ahead. On each crossing, choose one thing to carry over and one thing to set down. Write the marker on a slip of paper, and say the words aloud. Nothing needs to be burned or buried. The crossing is finished when you keep the terms you set.

Where this comes from: Sea-voyage vows appear in Icelandic sagas as a story pattern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the crossing you are in now. Name the bank behind you and the bank ahead. Write what you will carry over and what you will set down. Give it three dated lines.*

Doorways you use every day

Every doorway is an edge between outside and inside. Folk custom treats it that way. People have put juniper sprigs above the lintel, which is the beam over the door, and a pinch of salt along the sill. A verse is said when going out, and a breath is taken when coming home. You touch the door frame many times a day without noticing. This habit asks you to notice it once.

That doorway marks the edge of your home, the way a riverbank marks the edge of a river. Small, steady care keeps the inside calm. Juniper, salt, and short verses are folk survivals (old habits that lasted in ordinary households) from many districts, not one single ritual. A calendar can turn these scraps into a habit you repeat.

Start with the door you use most. Sweep the sill and clear the corners. A store-bought sprig of green is enough. Use one short line for leaving and one for coming home. Say them every day for a month. Doing it every day matters more than doing it grandly. Your hands and your voice do the work. A door kept with care helps the whole house feel settled.

Where this comes from: Threshold habits come from folk custom in many districts.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose the doorway you use most. Clean it and add a green sprig in fifteen minutes. Write your two short lines and today's date. Give it three dated lines.*

Dawn, dusk, and Yule night

Twice a day, the light is neither fully day nor fully night. Once a year, at Yule (midwinter), the season does something similar. In Icelandic folk belief, the mounds stood open on Yule night and the dead could walk near the living. Dawn and dusk carry a smaller daily version of that opening. The house is quiet, and the edges show clearly. Birds wake or settle as the light shifts. Even a city window shows the change.

In old stories, edges were meeting times. Bargains were made there, and messages were passed there. Several Icelandic sagas follow this pattern. The phrase thin places for such spots is modern. The habit underneath is older. Showing up on time at the edge was the offering. Think of each edge as a meeting you keep.

Try three dawns or three dusks in a row. Sit at a window or on a step for ten minutes. Do not rush. Notice the light and count three sounds. If cloud hides the sun, keep the same hour anyway. By the third day, the change in light should be easier to notice.

Some old northern and Old English texts blame certain sicknesses on outside beings. The northern books name álfar (alfar), elves, and mara, a night-presser who sits on sleepers. Their touch is said to weigh on the body. This appears in Icelandic sagas and in Old English charms. Old English texts use ælfe (aelfe) for stitch and fever, and mære (maere) for the night mare. This appears in Old English leechbooks and charms. This book takes only the habit of watching the edges. It does not diagnose or treat illness. If you are unwell, see a clinician.

Where this comes from: Meetings at edges appear in Icelandic sagas as a story pattern. The phrase "thin places" is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose dawn or dusk. Keep it three days in a row for ten minutes at the same window or step. Write light and three sounds after each sit. Give it three dated lines.*

Well visit: go, tidy, listen. Write the date, place, what you tidied, what you heard, and what you left.

Sea-road worksheet: what you are crossing, what you carry over, what you set down mid-water.

The doorway rite

Spend four minutes at the door you use most. Do this once a month or at each turning of the seasons. Sweep the sill down to the bare step. Put fresh salt where the step meets the street. Hang a store-bought juniper sprig above the lintel, or store-bought rosemary if juniper is not on hand. Take a breath inside, then say one verse as you step out. Use store-bought herbs only, and do not eat or drink them. This ritual (the same steps in the same order each time) takes care, not fuss.

Each part comes from everyday household habits in folk custom, not from one old book. Sweeping clears dust out of the doorway. Salt marks the line between inside and out. Green over the lintel is a sign of care for the house. A verse going out and thanks coming home bracket the day. The monthly schedule is modern, and this book says so. Nothing is burned or buried. The broom does much of the work before any words are spoken.

When you come home, pause in the doorway for one breath and say one thank-you. This closes the going out. Four minutes covers both going and coming. Missing a month does not undo anything. Start again with the sweep, salt, green, and verse, with no penalty. A door kept this way helps the people inside feel settled. Keep the sweep and the words simple.

Where this comes from: The threshold habits come from folk custom. The monthly schedule was written for this book.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Write your going-out verse and your coming-home thanks tonight. Give sill, salt, green, and both lines. Keep them ready in four dated lines.*

Three-day sit log: dawn or dusk, for three days. Write the light, the sounds, and what changed. Date each day.

Runes

Stones with staves

Runes cut on stone

Run your finger along a stone's cuts in low light and you feel the shape before you read it. A rune is a letter of the old runic alphabet. The Elder row, the older set in order, has twenty-four runes. They are cut on spearheads, on gold bracteates (thin gold medallions), and on standing stones, from roughly the second to the eighth century. The row begins fehu-uruz-þurisaz-ansuz-raidō-kenaz. Those six runes give the row its name, futhark, which is taken from its first six letters. The Kylver stone on Gotland carries the whole Elder row in order. Centuries later, the Younger row uses sixteen signs, in short-twig and long-branch forms. It was cut from roughly the ninth to the twelfth century on stones such as Rök and Jelling.

The two rows differ in length, not in purpose. The Elder row spells things out fully. Its twenty-four runes are grouped into three families of eight. Later books call them the kin of Freyr, Hagall, and Týr. The Younger row shortens the writing to sixteen signs and leaves more to the reader. Stones give family names and memories. They say a stone was raised for a father. They never give spells or fortunes. The medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon) pair each rune with a short saying. Wealth must move. Ice gives no grip. A torch shows the way. Read each saying slowly, one at a time.

Your hands can learn the runes before your mind does. The first cuts were made by hands holding chisels, and hands still learn them best. Draw straight lines with a ruler, say each name aloud, and count the branches on each rune. Using your hand and your voice together helps the shapes stick. If the whole row feels like too much, start with the first six runes.

Where this comes from: The rows are cut on stones from the 2nd to the 12th century, and the rune poems give the verses. The study practice is modern.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Copy the Elder row one evening and the Younger row the next, using a ruler for straight lines. Sound each name and count three branches. Write which row your hand prefers and where the runes match. Give it four dated lines.*

Seven runes for your journal

This book uses seven short runes. Each rune has a saying that the medieval rune poems give. Fehu is cattle and wealth, which must move to stay alive. Uruz is the strong aurochs, a wild ox, pulling through mud. Þurisaz (Thurisaz) is the thorn that guards by pricking whoever grips it. Ansuz is the mouth of Óðinn, speaking counsel. Raidō (Raidho) is the road and riding, which can be smooth or hard on the feet. Kenaz is the torch that shows the evening work. Hagalaz is the hail that breaks roofs and bows to no one. Say each name aloud. Each rune fits a small slip of paper with its name on one side and its saying on the other.

These rune names and sayings come from the medieval rune poems. The Norwegian, Icelandic, and Anglo-Saxon rune poems each speak in their own voice. Everything else in this practice is modern, and this book says so. The book does not claim that Viking Age people cast runes like this. The set is narrowed to seven because it suits a journal rather than a temple. The three-rune spread is modern. It sets out root, trunk, and branch from left to right.

Ask one true question and boil it down to a single line. Lay three slips from left to right for root, trunk, and branch. The root shows what the matter rests on. The trunk shows what is steady. The branch shows what may grow. Ten minutes with pen and slips is enough. Write the date at the top of the page. Keep every cast in the same notebook pages across the months. Casts can show patterns that one night cannot.

Where this comes from: The seven meanings are from the medieval rune poems (Norwegian, Icelandic, Anglo-Saxon). The narrowed set and the three-rune spread were written for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Boil one true question to a single line tonight. Draw three runes for root, trunk, and branch. Date the cast and write three plain sentences. Keep every cast in the same pages.

Staves

use them honestly

Galdrastaves are late; use them honestly

Galdrastaves are late. They are not Viking Age runes. A galdrastave is a magic sign drawn in a charm book (a book of spells and charms). The earliest bound staves in Iceland appear in AM 434 a 12mo, an Icelandic charm book of the late 1400s. They were drawn beside remedies. The books many people know are early modern. Galdrabók (Galdrabok) dates to the 17th century. Lbs 4375 8vo dates to the 1860s. They mix a Christian frame, with Latin, runes, and pictures together. Ægishjálmr (Aegishjalmr), Helm of Awe, has old poetry behind it. Vegvísir (Vegvisir), the way-pointer, dates to the 1860s. It appears in the Huld manuscript, a 19th-century Icelandic collection. It is not a Viking Age sign.

They stand as early modern folk practice, not Iron Age practice. In books such as Galdrabók, their power comes from calling on Christ, Mary, and angels alongside older names. They were drawn on paper or wood and carried. Calling them Viking amulets (lucky charms worn on the body) is a modern label. Kept in their own period, they stay accurate.

Draw one stave on paper this week. Choose Ægishjálmr or a stave from AM 434 a 12mo, and write the date, book, and purpose beside it. Carry the paper for a day. Then bury it in soil or recycle it, with thanks. Use paper only, not skin, in this book.

Where this comes from: The staves come from AM 434 a, Galdrabók (17th century), and the Huld manuscript (1860s), all late. This book leaves out any Viking Age use.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Copy one stave on paper this week. Note the date, the book, and the purpose. Carry it for a day, then bury it in soil or recycle it. Log what held in three dated lines.*

Draw your valknútr (a sign of three linked triangles): trace the threes that matter to you, such as breath, blood, bone, or your own.

Valknútr (Valknut) is old; the rest is newer

The valknútr (knot of the slain) is three triangles locked together. It is cut on Viking Age picture stones beside riders and ships. Its link to Óðinn is only suggested, by the scenes it appears in, not by a written label. Many people today read it as a sign of threes that matter, such as breath, blood, and bone, or three of your own choosing. Some carved stones are worn but plain, and their shapes can be hard to read. Trace the turn with your hand first. Your hand learns it faster than your eyes.

The other marks belong to other places and times. The triquetra (a knot of three pointed loops) belongs to Early Christian and medieval art. Most tangled knotwork sold as a Viking badge is either medieval or modern craft. Enjoy them as craft. Called Viking, they mislead. Of the signs in this chapter, only the valknútr is Viking Age. The rest is newer. Loving them as craft takes nothing away.

Sketch a valknútr on paper first, showing three triangles interlaced. Note the date each time. Next, draw it in chalk on your own step, and score (cut shallow lines in) a loaf of bread before baking. Each takes under half an hour. Note where each mark went and what washed away. Practice a little at a time until your wrist knows the turn.

Where this comes from: The valknútr is cut on Viking Age picture stones. The triquetra comes from Christian and medieval art.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Describe your valknútr in words, then draw it. Note which way its points turn and where it went. Give paper, chalk, and bread dates in three dated lines.*

Draw and mark tracker: where did your valknútr go this month?

- ☐ Paper copy — date
- ☐ Doorway chalk — date
- ☐ Bread scored — date
- ☐ Stitched or drawn on cloth — date
- ☐ Garden or path marking — date
- ☐ Gift given with the mark — date
- ☐ What held, what washed away?

Galdr: Charms

Words in old books

Galdr: the sung charm

A charm is a short set of words said or sung for a purpose. Óðinn in the Hávamál lists the songs he knows, the way a carpenter lists tools. Each one has its work named. The Hávamál says one song blunts an enemy's blade. Another loosens chains from the wrists. Another calms a storm for rowers. Another wakes courage in tired men. The Sigrdrífumál in the Poetic Edda shows the same pattern in a smaller way. Brynhildr teaches Sigurðr rune songs for sword, ale, and healing. A galdr is a charm that is sung or spoken aloud, not one thought in silence. The voice does the work.

The voice is the teaching. The tune is not recorded. No melody survives in the Poetic Edda. The Hávamál gives purposes and boasts. It never gives notes on a staff. The medieval rune poems give names and meanings. They never give a music book. Any modern galdr with set tunes, robes, and staged circle work is a modern rebuilding. It is honest when called so. What the sources show is plainer. It is a verse learned by heart, said aloud, and said with care.

One verse learned by heart and spoken aloud in a low voice keeps the old shape. Speak it plainly at the same window three mornings in a row, without strain. A sung charm here means practiced words that calm your nerves, not weather you command. Keep your voice steady and unforced.

Where this comes from: The charm list is in the Hávamál and the rune counsel is in the Sigrdrífumál, both in the Poetic Edda. No tunes survive, so any modern tune is rebuilt.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name the verse you will learn by heart. Speak it at the same window three mornings. Write the date, the verse, and what steadied you. Give it three dated lines.*

Words in old books

Old northern voices survive in plain lines inside physician's handbooks and the Old English leechbooks (old medical handbooks). The Merseburg-type charms from mainland Europe are close cousins in language. They speak healing over bone and blood. They say joint to joint, blood to blood.

Surviving northern words lean toward protection and sometimes healing. This chapter follows only the protective side. Four workings are here, and each one protects or blesses. To ward means to guard. There is a walk around the room, a knot for the road, a bundle for the door, and a blessing of water. Nothing here curses or binds another person. Keep any words short enough to remember.

Cangemi's PhD thesis (Luthien Cangemi, UCL, 2024) gathers the spoken healing charms into four shapes that return in the Old English leechbooks and the Merseburg-type charms. One is a blessing spoken over the sick. One is a firm command that tells illness to leave. One is a holy story told as an example. One is a prayer said alongside the words. Any speaking in this book stays rebuilt household protection only. It is never a cure or a prescription. If you are ill, see a clinician.

Where this comes from: The Merseburg-type charms and the Old English leechbooks are old written sources.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Name one part of your life that needs guarding this week. Write it in one line with no defeating and no fixing. Pin it where you work. Give it three dated lines.*

Circling and cleansing

Walking a ring around a person or place, with your feet and your voice, is an old form of protection. The walk is called circling. The turn runs sunwise, meaning clockwise in the northern world, across northern custom. You walk around the person or place with a blessing until the circle closes. Beside it stands the body cleansing (a blessing with juniper or water). It cleanses the body part by part, as if dressing for the day. End with thanks to close the ring. Carl-Herman Tillhagen, a Swedish folk-custom collector, recorded Swedish farm protection customs as folk practice, so it is a sound source.

Both shapes come down through a few old written hints and everyday folk practice. They appear across prayers and custom and were not invented here. The meaning for a home is simple. The ring says this ground is watched. The cleansing says this body is dressed for the day. A hallway, a garden bed, and a bedside all suit the ring. Your own words work well before sleep. Having someone walk the ring with you makes it more meaningful.

Walk one small circle around a single room. Say a short line of protection and close with thanks at the door. Keep it under twenty minutes. For the cleansing, say six short lines, one for each part from head to foot, and touch each part as you say it. If you use juniper, use store-bought sprigs only, and do not eat or steep them. Repeat it often, and the habit will feel easier.

Where this comes from: Circling and cleansing come from folk custom. Tillhagen recorded Swedish farm customs.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Walk one circling tonight around a single room. Speak plain protection and close with thanks. Write your six-line cleansing from head to foot. Log where you walked in three dated lines.*

First working: the knot charm

You need a length of wool or linen cord. Folk custom across many districts ties protection into knots. Tie three knots slowly. Say one short blessing line over each knot as you pull it snug. The first knot is for the body, the second for the home, and the third for the road. Say each line aloud on your out-breath as you tighten the knot. Three knots and three lines make one charm.

Knot-tying for protection is folk survival. It comes from many households, not one ritual. This renewal habit is modern practice built on that custom. A charm that is never checked can fade, so the practice includes renewal. At each turning of the season, untie the knots and tie them fresh, saying the lines anew. Retying is part of the care. Write a date on a tag or in the margin, so you know when the next turn is due.

Make each line short enough to say in one breath. Tie the cord at a table. Then hang it high, near a draughty window or door, where daily brushing will not wear it thin. The work takes about twenty minutes with hands and voice. When the cord frays, wash it and tie it again. If the cord feels damp, let it dry before you hang it. Check the knots each time you walk past, and retie any that have come loose.

Where this comes from: Knot-tying for protection comes from folk custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Draft three short knot lines, each brief enough for one breath. Tie your cord tonight and hang it. Write lines, place, and date. Give it three dated lines.*

Second working: the doorway bundle

A small bundle above the lintel holds household names. Tie a store-bought juniper twig and a store-bought rowan twig together with string. Rest a pinch of salt in a scrap of cloth. Write the names of the people under the roof on paper. Hang the bundle above the lintel of the door you use most, where you will see it each day. Keep the binding plain and the knot firm. Skip decoration. A thimbleful of salt is plenty. It is a token, not a supply.

Juniper at the threshold, salt at the sill, and green over the door appear in folk custom. They come from many households, not one old recipe. Seasonal renewal is a modern habit with an older feel. At each turn of the season, fresh salt and fresh green go back in, with names spoken aloud as you set them back. Clearing out the old with care matters as much as hanging the new. Each name you put back inside keeps its place.

The bundle takes half an hour with string and shop supplies. At renewal, pour old salt onto bare soil away from plants and paths. Never throw it in the bin beside the door. Put old green into soil or running water with thanks. Never bin it. Clear the old bundle with thanks before you make a new one.

Where this comes from: The doorway ingredients come from folk custom.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Make your bundle in half an hour. List contents and names in your journal tonight. Renew with fresh salt and green at the turning. Write all in three dated lines.

Third working: the water blessing

Clean water in a small bottle brings a little of the well indoors. Draw it from your own tap with thanks, or from a well where you asked leave and took only a little. Keep it sealed apart for blessings, and label it not for drinking. Flick drops sunwise around a room, across the threshold, or onto your brow. This follows an old pattern called aspersion, which means sprinkling. It is a small household copy of well custom. Keep the bottle high and away from drinking vessels and small hands.

This working is reconstructed from well custom, not copied from one ritual. It keeps the habits of asking leave, taking little, and turning sunwise. The rule is to use little. Never drink from wild water. Never fill a bottle from a protected spring. Never take more than the blessing needs. Change the water each month. Pour the old water onto plant roots, so nothing is wasted or harmed. Little and often is the whole method. Drops, not drinks.

Keep the bottle near a spot you use every day, such as your desk or your bedroom door. Opening, flicking, thanking, and closing takes minutes. If you are unsure where to start, use the door you use most, since it needs the most care. A little water given often keeps the house feeling cared for.

Where this comes from: The water blessing was rebuilt from well custom.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose where your bottle will live and what it blesses first. Bless once and log date and place. Renew when the month turns. Give it three dated lines.*

Uncrossing and repair

Charms can wear out, tangle, or get dirty. That is a sign they need care, not a sign of failure. Folk custom expects renewal, the way a house expects dusting. Uncrossing means taking the working apart gently. Knots are untied and cords washed. Bundles are emptied and sills swept. Water is poured out and bottles scrubbed. Name what slipped without shame and without hurry. Work in daylight with the windows open. Taking things apart feels like tidying, because it is.

The remade working should be one step steadier than before. Keep the new parts simple, so they are easy to check next time. Give the new working a week before you change it again. Use a stronger line on the knot, a neater round at the door, and walk the circle once a week for a while instead of monthly. The renewal pattern is reconstructed from custom. The repair shape is modern and called so. Mending matters more than a perfect first try.

Pick one charm that feels worn. Spend twenty minutes to uncross, clean, and remake it. Write down what slipped and what steadies it. Do this in a calm moment, not in a rush. Close with thanks. Notice how the house feels the next morning and write it down. Write the date beside the new work, so you can see how long it lasts.

Where this comes from: The renewal pattern was rebuilt from custom. The repair steps were written for this book.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Find one working that needs it tonight. Uncross, clean, remake in twenty minutes. Write what slipped in one line and what steadies it in the next. Give it three dated lines.

Charm log: write which working you made, the date, and who it was for. Record all three.

Home ward tracker, week one: walk the circling and mark each day.

☐ Day 1 — walked?

☐ Day 2 — walked?

☐ Day 3 — walked?

☐ Day 4 — walked?

☐ Day 5 — walked?

☐ Day 6 — walked?

☐ Day 7 — walked + knots checked?

☐ What held this week?

Home ward tracker, week two: walk the circling and mark each day.

☐ Day 8 — walked?

☐ Day 9 — walked?

☐ Day 10 — walked?

☐ Day 11 — walked?

☐ Day 12 — walked?

☐ Day 13 — walked?

☐ Day 14 — walked + bundle checked?

☐ What held across both weeks?

Ancestors

Mound-neighbors

Mound-neighbors

Low green mounds in the fields are old burial places. Haugr, the burial mound, stands in Icelandic sagas as the home of the dead. In those sagas the dead keep watch over cattle and weather. People greeted them with toasts poured at the door-stone and kept their paths swept. Egils saga (Egil's Saga) and other Icelandic sagas show gifts laid and words spoken at mounds. This book does not try to wake them. In this telling, your people are not far off. They are neighbors near dusk, close enough to be remembered at the table.

This closeness is gentle. It is for comfort, not proof. Mounds and ship-settings (stone outlines shaped like ships) are found by archaeologists, the people who dig up and study past sites. You can visit them. The talking dead come from Icelandic sagas. That is a story pattern, not a map. Nothing here asks you to prove or perform anything. One shared meal a year is enough. A card, a letter, or a list of names also works. These are small ways to remember. Grief is welcome here, and so are good manners.

A name can be honored with no ritual at all. Light a candle, speak a name, and remember one true thing. That is all it takes. Set the candle on a steady, flat surface, away from curtains and paper. Never leave a flame unattended. Put the candle out before bed. Fuller remembrance is on the supper page when you are ready. There is no test. Speak a name and be kind.

Where this comes from: Mounds appear in Icelandic sagas and in archaeology.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Rest with one name tonight. Light a candle if you like, speak the name aloud, and never leave it burning unattended. Write one true sentence before sleep. Give it three dated lines and the time you put the candle out.*

The quiet supper script

This supper sets one more plate than the living need. The first half of the meal is eaten in silence. Serve a simple, hot meal. Soup, bread, or a dish they used to make can be the food. Light a candle for each name you will speak. Keep an empty chair for them. Eat together in quiet, and the dead share the hour with you.

Halfway through, speak each name aloud with one true sentence. Offer a thanks, a memory, or something you never said. Then eat the second half while keeping them in mind. The shape comes down through folk custom. Many households kept it. This script is one gentle modern version. It is meant for Yule or Winter Nights. Once a year is plenty. Steady remembrance matters more than grandeur. Tears are fine.

After the meal, close with thanks and put out the candles. Never leave a candle burning when you leave the room. Leave a little food out for birds or neighbors in the morning. The whole practice fits in an hour, not counting the dishes. Leave the names by the bed until morning.

Where this comes from: The quiet supper comes from folk custom, with hints in Icelandic sagas.

> GRIMOIRE PROMPT
>
> *Choose the menu and names tonight. Keep the supper inside an hour at Yule or Winter Nights. Write the menu, names, and morning notes. Give it three dated lines.*

Ancestor card, first: write the name, dates, one story, one thing they left you, and one question.

Ancestor card, second: write the name, dates, one story, one thing they left you, and one question.

Grief letter and roll call: write a letter you will not send, then list the names you will speak at Yule.

Oath

Go on reading

Your vow page: fill it in. I will keep ___ for 30 days. I will not ___. Witnessed by ___.

Books behind this book

Primary sources, in translation

The Poetic Edda — trans. Carolyne Larrington, or trans. Jackson Crawford (Hackett, 2015).

Snorri Sturluson, The Prose Edda — trans. Anthony Faulkes.

Völsunga Saga (The Saga of the Völsungs) — trans. Jesse Byock; trans. Jackson Crawford.

Egils saga — in translation.

The rune poems: Norwegian, Icelandic, Anglo-Saxon — in translation.

Witnesses, histories, law

Tacitus, Germania.

Ibn Fadlan, account of the Rus burial on the Volga.

Adam of Bremen, Gesta Hammaburgensis Ecclesiae Pontificum.

Landnámabók.

Grágás (the Grey Goose Laws).

Sigvatr Þórðarson, Austrfararvísur.

Ynglinga Saga.

The Merseburg Charms.

Old English leechbooks.

Scholarship and teaching

Jackson Crawford — YouTube channel: Norse mythology, language, sagas, and culture.

Luthien Cangemi — The Art of Healing in Medieval Iceland, PhD thesis, UCL, 2024.

Carl-Herman Tillhagen — Swedish folk custom records.

Go on reading

Four old texts go further into this subject. Read small parts in public translations before you buy anything. The Poetic Edda in Larrington's translation opens with the seeress and the counsel of Hávamál. Snorri Sturluson's Prose Edda in Faulkes's version tells the stories plainly. The Völsunga Saga in Byock's translation follows Sigurðr to the pyre. Egils saga tells of a poem that buys back Egil's own head in York. Borrow them first, so you can judge them fairly.

Read these books first as stories, and second as lessons. They are original old texts, in translation, not summaries. They reward slow reading. For each part, ask what happened, what it means at home, and what small act answers it. Let the answer settle over a week. A chapter a week is a good pace. Keep a notebook beside you, and write your answers there.

Start with one book and one starting day. The next morning, sit in the same spot and read the next section. An hour or less per sitting is plenty. Pick a time that suits you and keep it. When you finish, pass the book on, and mark the page that held you longest. Keeping to your reading plan is a small vow you can keep.

Where this comes from: The primary texts to read next. Go meet them.

GRIMOIRE PROMPT

Commit to one book and one starting day. Begin the next morning in the same spot. Write book, day, and the page that holds you longest. Give it three dated lines.